Persuasion and Prejudice: Are South Korean Attitudes Toward Immigration Open to Change?

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Abstract

How do framing cues shape immigration attitudes where demographic need is acute but ethnocultural priors remain strong? We examine South Korea, where the government has framed immigration as a response to economic competitiveness and falling fertility (In, 2024; Park, 2024). A nationally representative survey experiment (n=1,999) crosses three between-subjects framing arms with a choice-based conjoint on immigrant admission profiles. The findings are asymmetric across two levels. At the policy level, the growth cue produces ideologically differentiated effects. Centrists and conservatives consolidate the status quo, and progressives shift toward restriction. At the admission level, the pooled origin and ethnicity penalties the cross-national literature identifies as the primary locus of discrimination are unchanged across arms within the design's minimum detectable interaction effect, and within-subgroup variation is modest and cancels in aggregate. The cues move what respondents say they want about immigration totals. They do not decrease origin- or ethnicity-based discrimination over who would be admitted.

Keywords: immigration, persuasion, framing, conjoint, status quo activation, South Korea

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1 Introduction

South Korean immigration policy and attitudes are shaped by a demographic and economic case for opening, set against attitudes of conditional acceptance. The case is quite strong. South Korea's total fertility rate sits well below the replacement level, the population is ageing rapidly, and labour shortages in agriculture, manufacturing, and care work outpace what the existing visa programs cover (Clemens, 2024; Choi et al., 2024; In, 2024). For the public, the same demographic pressures provide a potential national-interest basis for openness, although the immigration attitudes literature covering South Korea documents persistent ambivalence rather than uniform support (Kim and Park, 2023; Gouda and Song, 2024). If anything, there are reasons to believe that the population might not be so eager to open up. South Korea has long operated a stratified visa regime in which co-ethnic Koreans from advanced economies are privileged over Joseonjok and Goryeoin co-ethnics from China and the former Soviet Union, who are in turn privileged over non-ethnic Korean migrants from middle-income origins (Seol and Skrentny, 2009; Chung, 2020a; Denney and Green, 2021). The country's foreign-born share, even after a decade of growth, sits below five percent of the population.

In democracies, immigration policy reform depends on social support (Levy and Wright, 2020), so understanding whether elite messaging can shift public opinion matters for what reform is politically feasible. Three families of expectations matter for this question. The classical persuasion tradition, organized by the Generalizing Persuasion framework of Druckman (2022) and the competitive-frames program of Chong and Druckman (2007), predicts that strong, broadly applicable frames should shift policy preferences in the direction of the framed argument. A second line of work, anchored by Kustov et al. (2021) and Kustov (2024), finds that immigration preferences are unusually stable and that pro-immigration messaging more reliably raises issue salience than changes direction. A third line, anchored by Arceneaux and Nicholson (2023) on status quo bias and by recent work on the durability of immigration attitudes through the European refugee crisis and the war in Ukraine (Bansak et al., 2023a; Letki et al., 2024), predicts that frames consolidating existing elite consensus activate the status quo position over alternatives.

This study asks whether frames the South Korean government has itself advanced since at least 2018

(In, 2024; Park, 2024) resonate with the public and move opinions. Specifically, we test whether messages framing immigration as an answer to South Korea's low fertility rate or as essential for maintaining economic growth alter policy preferences and reduce origin- and ethnicity-based penalties at the immigrant admission stage, which are attributes on which South Korean attitudes discriminate (Denney and Green, 2021). These are plausible pro-immigration cues precisely because demographic need is acute and the growth frame has broad elite support. They are also difficult cues because they land in a setting where ethnocultural priors about belonging remain strong. We therefore ask whether any effects vary with respondents' baseline sociotropic orientation (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Valentino et al., 2019), and we add subgroup analysis by ideology, partisanship, and sociotropic group because these are the cleavages along which Korean elite messaging would be expected to differentially land.

To address these questions we use a two-part empirical strategy on a nationally representative online panel of 1,999 native-born South Koreans fielded through Qualtrics in January 2024. First, a between-subjects framing experiment evaluates the impact of growth- and fertility-cue messages on stated policy preferences over the size of the foreign-born population. Second, a forced-choice conjoint of immigrant admission profiles isolates how seven attributes, including origin, ethnicity, occupation, Korean language proficiency, application reason, and employment plan, structure individual preferences over which immigrants should be admitted. Each respondent evaluates seven paired-profile tasks, with the framing cue reinforced after the third task to mitigate fade-out (Bansak et al., 2018).

Two findings emerge. At the policy-preference level, the growth cue produces ideologically differentiated effects on stated immigration policy. Centrists and conservatives consolidate support for the status quo, while self-placed progressives shift toward restriction. The pattern replicates partially on partisanship and is consistent with status quo activation among groups whose priors are compatible with the executive's sociotropic argument, alongside a source-cue reaction among groups that read the message as out-party-aligned. The fertility cue produces no comparable shift in policy preference.

At the level of who respondents would admit, the pooled origin and ethnicity penalties that the cross-national literature identifies as the primary locus of immigration discrimination (Denney and Green, 2021; Fraser and Cheng, 2024) are essentially unchanged across the three framing arms. Disaggregating by ideology and partisanship produces modest within-subgroup variation in the direction the cues push the China-versus-United-States gap, a narrowing among progressives and a widening on the right, but the cancelling subgroup pattern leaves the pooled penalty intact and does not decrease the ethnicity penalty in any subgroup. The remaining attributes in the design (occupation, Korean language, application reason, employment plan, sex) likewise operate at the cross-national magnitudes and are not displaced by the cues.

The findings together identify an asymmetry between the two levels at which respondents process pro-immigration cues. The cues shift what respondents say they want about immigration totals. They do not decrease origin- or ethnicity-based discrimination at the admission stage.

2 South Korean Immigration in Review

South Korea is a textbook case of what migration scholars term a *new immigration country*, a state that transitioned from net emigration to net immigration only in the late twentieth century, lacks the deep policy infrastructure of its Western European counterparts, and confronts the politics of incorporation under conditions of rapid demographic decline (Chung, 2020b; Liu-Farrer, 2020). The category was originally applied to southern Europe, where Italy, Spain, Portugal, and Greece shifted from sending to receiving countries between the late 1970s and 1990s. The framework now travels well to East Asia, where Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan share late entry into the global migration system, ethnonational ideologies of nationhood, and labor shortages produced by sustained sub-replacement fertility (Chung, 2020b; Maeda and Strausz, 2025). The South Korean case is on the steeper end of the curve. The foreign-born share has climbed from less than half a percent in 1990 to just under five percent in 2024, with registered foreign residents exceeding two million (Ministry of Justice, 2024), even as total fertility has remained well below the replacement level.

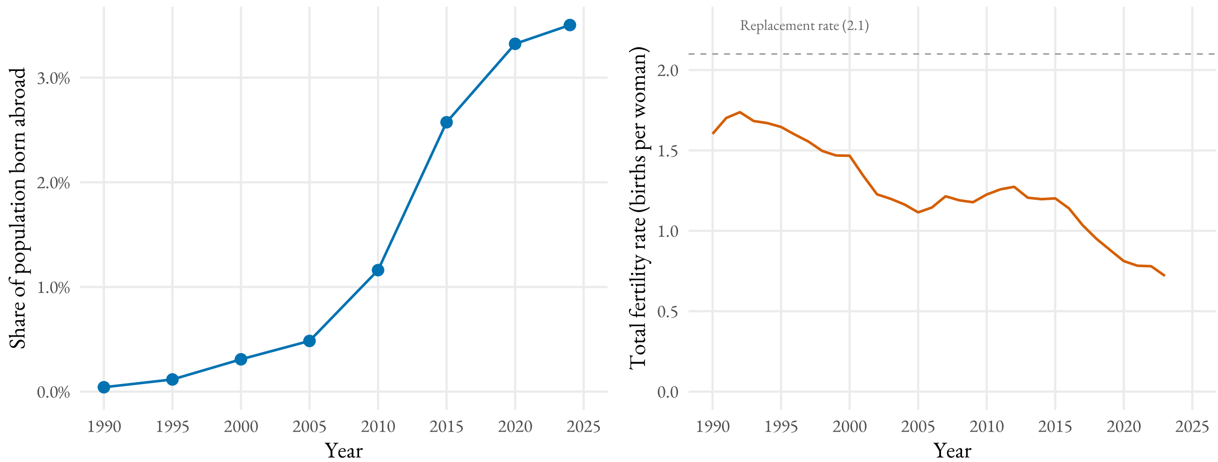

Figure 1: South Korea's foreign-born share (left) and total fertility rate (right), 1990-2024.

Note: Foreign-born share is the share of the resident population born in another country, from UN DESA's International Migrant Stock estimates compiled by Our World in Data. Total fertility rate is the average number of births per woman, from the UN World Population Prospects (2024 revision) compiled by Our World in Data. Both series begin in 1990. Migrant-stock data are reported at five-year intervals (1990-2020) plus the latest 2024 estimate. The dashed line marks the population-replacement rate of 2.1 births per woman.

Most foreign residents in South Korea come from neighboring Asian countries, with Chinese nationals, including ethnic Koreans (*Joseonjok*), comprising the largest group at over 900,000. Following China, the most common origins are Vietnam (approximately 270,000), Thailand (202,000), the United States (160,000),[1] Uzbekistan (87,000), and the Philippines (64,000) (Ministry of Justice, 2024).

The legal architecture that channels this growth produces an explicit hierarchy of admission. The Employment Permit System (EPS), introduced in 2004, brings in low-wage workers from fifteen designated Asian countries on temporary, employer-tied contracts, while the Overseas Korean Act (OKA) and the F-4 visa regime offer extensive labor-market and residency rights to ethnic Koreans abroad. The OKA initially excluded co-ethnics from China and the former Soviet Union and prioritized Korean Americans, a structural choice Seol and Skrentny (2009) calls *hierarchical nationhood*, in which bloodline and class are bundled and co-ethnicity alone does not confer equal standing. Two decades on, this hierarchy continues to shape policy and lived experience. Joseonjok and Goryeoin migrants face a narrower set of social and economic opportunities than co-ethnics from advanced economies and consistently report higher rates

[1] American figures include US military personnel (approximately 28,500).

of perceived discrimination (Song, 2018, 2023; Chung, 2020a). Yu (2023) extends the argument with ethnographic evidence from state-sponsored integration centers, showing that frontline staff sort migrants along an explicit class-and-nationality grid that privileges Western, professional, and ethnically Korean profiles and disadvantages Southeast Asian and Joseonjok workers.

Public-opinion work since 2020 confirms that these institutional hierarchies are mirrored at the individual level. Denney and Green (2021) use a conjoint design to show a stable preference ordering that runs from co-ethnic, high-skill, high-income origins down through Southeast Asian and Chinese profiles. Denney and Green (2024) extend the analysis to integration preferences and find that even when respondents are evaluating co-ethnic migrants, support is conditional on signals of cultural and economic distance from the host society. Gouda and Song (2024) document that economic, cultural, and demographic factors all contribute to attitudes but that the cultural dimension carries disproportionate weight. Choi et al. (2024) adds a useful boundary condition. Respondents in regions experiencing the sharpest population decline are more open to multicultural immigration policy, suggesting that demographic pressure can shift attitudes where it is felt locally rather than as an abstract national figure. Kim and Park (2023) report that Koreans simultaneously acknowledge the economic case for immigration and worry about its social consequences, an ambivalence that helps explain why salient frames seldom shift policy preferences in either direction.

Policy discourse under recent administrations has tracked the same ambivalence. The Moon Jae-in government (2017-2022) extended visa programs for high-skilled workers and integration support for marriage-migrant families. Yoon Suk-yeol (2022-2025) tied immigration more explicitly to demographic and labor-market necessity but produced limited reform (Jung, 2023). The Lee Jae-myung administration, sworn in in June 2025, has been quiet on the issue. Migrant policy was largely absent from the 2025 campaign (Korea Times, 2025), and Lee's first-year policy agenda has tilted toward restriction. The E-9 quota for low-skilled foreign workers fell from 165,000 in 2024 to 80,000 for 2026, a forty-percent cut justified in domestic-wage-protection terms (Korea Herald, 2025). The silence is itself informative. It indicates that even a progressive government facing the deepest demographic shock in the OECD has not judged the political return on a pro-immigration platform to be positive, which is a useful contextual data point for the framing-experiment results that follow.

2.1 Persuasion, Framing, and Pathways from Cues to Policy Preferences

Whether elite cues can shift public opinion on immigration is among the longest-running questions in the comparative study of attitudes, and the answer has shifted across three generations of research. We adopt the Generalizing Persuasion framework of Druckman (2022) as the organizing scheme. The framework decomposes any persuasion attempt into actors, treatments, outcomes, and settings, and it allows us to be explicit about what kind of persuasion our growth-and-fertility cues attempt, why they differ from the partisan or elite-source cues that dominate the U.S. literature, and which family of empirical predictions we should evaluate. The treatment is a sociotropic policy frame. The receivers are the South Korean general population. The outcome is a stated policy preference over the size of the foreign-born population, and the setting is one in which the government has itself been the loudest sponsor of the frames in question.

The starting point in any modern account of immigration framing is the competitive-frames program of Chong and Druckman (2007) and Chong and Druckman (2013). They show that strong frames typically dominate weak ones, that competition between frames tends to attenuate but not erase persuasion, and that the timing and repetition of counterframes matter for whether an initial frame survives. The critical finding for our purposes is that credibility, applicability, and resonance do the persuasive work in low-partisanship settings. In a context like ours, where the two frames we manipulate are both currently advanced by the South Korean government and are difficult to map onto a left-right cleavage, the Chong-Druckman model predicts that they should function much like the strong, broadly applicable frames in their experiments.

A first generation of immigration-framing studies took the persuasion premise at face value and asked whether economic, cultural, or humanitarian frames shifted policy preferences. Brader et al. (2008) showed that messages emphasizing immigrants' negative economic and social impact increased restrictionist preferences, especially when paired with cues about Latino origin, with anxiety serving as the mediating mechanism. Bansak et al. (2016), in a fifteen-country conjoint of asylum-seeker profiles, found that respondents reward economic potential, sympathetic biography, and Christian (rather than Muslim) origin. These two studies anchor what we call the *frame-as-preference-shift* tradition. Cues change beliefs about deservingness, threat, or contribution, which then change stated policy preferences. Translated into our setting, the expectation is straightforward. The government's pro-immigration sociotropic frames, which emphasize the contribution of the foreign-born to the labor force and to demographic stability, ought to shift South Koreans toward greater openness on immigration totals.

A second generation of work has cast doubt on this premise. Kustov et al. (2021), using nine panel datasets, document that immigration attitudes are unusually stable over time and survive substantial economic and political shocks, including the 2015 European refugee crisis. Dennison et al. (2023) extend this finding through the COVID-19 period. Policy preferences changed little during the pandemic, while the salience of the issue dropped substantially. Hopkins et al. (2019) and Grigorieff et al. (2020), using corrective-information designs, show that when respondents are told the actual size of the foreign-born population, beliefs update toward accuracy but policy preferences scarcely budge. In Switzerland, Bechtel et al. (2015) find that on the contested 2014 mass-immigration referendum, frames produced no discernible direct effect on the policy positions of voters. The cumulative implication is that, on a salient and contested issue like immigration, most people revise their attention to the question more readily than their preference. In settings where cultural or ethnonational priors are already strong, sociotropic cues may therefore raise the issue without changing the underlying direction of opinion.

Kustov (2024) converts this implication into a positive theoretical claim. He argues that pro-immigration messaging in particular should be evaluated by whether it raises *issue importance* among existing supporters. In a U.S. survey experiment of N=3,450, an information treatment about the national benefits of expanding legal immigration leaves opposition unchanged but increases the priority pro-immigration respondents place on the issue. Jin (2025) clarifies the picture by showing that whether issue salience translates into anti-immigrant attitudes depends on whether elite competition is structured around the issue. In the United Kingdom, where parties are polarized over immigration, increased salience strengthens restrictionist sentiment. In Germany, where elite consensus is more welcoming, salience increases without a corresponding restrictionist turn. South Korea sits closer to the German pole than the British one in the framing offered by sitting governments since at least 2018.

A third literature qualifies both of these accounts by emphasizing status quo bias and the boundaries of elite manipulation. Arceneaux and Nicholson (2023) argue that many political preferences are anchored in the existing policy baseline, making elite cues more likely to activate the status quo than to produce large directional change. The implication is especially relevant for immigration, where the current level of admission is cognitively available and where policy change can be framed as a risk to the existing social order. Coppock (2023) and Wood and Porter (2019) show across hundreds of issues that the predicted "backfire" or "boomerang" response to disliked information is rare, with most respondents updating, however slightly, in the direction the information argues. The early backfire results of Nyhan and Reifler (2010) did not, on replication, generalize. This rules out the strong version of the boomerang interpretation. A pro-immigration cue should not provoke uniform hostile reaction among receivers who already oppose immigration. Helbling et al. (2024) adds a complementary point about conditionality. Respondents balance numbers, selectivity, and rights against each other, and stated preferences shift when the question is framed as a tradeoff against an existing baseline. Why this conditionality should be especially constrained in the South Korean case, where sociotropic reasoning passes through an unusually cohesive set of ethnocultural priors, is developed in Appendix E.

Three expectations follow.

Expectation 1 *Druckman-style persuasion. Growth and fertility cues will shift South Koreans in the liberalizing direction, increasing the share who select* Increase *and decreasing the share who select* Decrease*.*

Expectation 2 *Kustov-style salience. Cues will leave the directional outcome flat while raising the importance respondents place on immigration policy. Under this expectation, a null on the policy-preference DV is informative because the expected change is attention, not direction.*

Expectation 3 *Status quo activation. Cues will consolidate support for maintaining current immigration levels, especially among respondents whose priors are compatible with the executive's sociotropic argument. Under this expectation, pro-immigration messaging activates the existing policy baseline and limits generalized liberalization.*

These expectations make distinct predictions on the directional outcome and are jointly testable at the population level. The Korean case is well suited to a direct test of them because the growth and fertility frames we evaluate are actual frames the government has used in published policy documents and in major-newspaper interviews, including the 2024 Korea Chamber of Commerce and Industry exchange that explicitly tied falling fertility to a need to lower "immigration barriers" (In, 2024; Park, 2024). As we show below, the pattern we estimate is closest to status quo activation but is politically asymmetric. The executive-branded growth message consolidates Maintain among groups whose priors are broadly compatible with the cue and is rejected by groups that read it as out-party-aligned, even when its content matches their priors. We develop that source-cue mechanism (Nicholson, 2012; Berinsky, 2009; Lenz, 2012) in Section 4 and the conclusion.

Both expectations address the same dependent variable, how much immigration the public says it wants. The conjoint half of the design tests a complementary question, whether the same cues alter who the public is willing to admit. Because pro-immigration framing might in principle operate at the policy aggregate, at one or more specific attributes (skill, origin, language, work history), at none of these, or differently at each, the conjoint analysis we report in Section 4.2 (with subgroup detail in Appendix C) is theoretically guided rather than pre-specified. We present marginal means and Control-referenced deltas across the six substantively-interesting attributes in the design and identify which attributes, if any, the cues shift. This is the approach the conjoint methodology literature recommends when the location of cue effects is not specified in advance (Hainmueller et al., 2014; Leeper et al., 2020), and the across-attribute presentation makes any selective reporting visible by construction.

3 Data and Methodology

This study uses a two-part empirical design to examine whether persuasion cues centered on demographic decline and economic growth shift South Korean public support for more immigration and reduce origin- and ethnicity-based penalties at the immigrant admission stage, which are attributes on which South Korean attitudes discriminate (Denney and Green, 2021). First, a between-subjects framing experiment tests whether growth- and fertility-cue messages alter immigration policy preferences. Second, a forced-choice conjoint analysis evaluates how the cues shape preferences over hypothetical immigrant applicants on attributes of origin, ethnicity, occupation, Korean language, application reason, employment plan, and sex. Both components draw on a nationally representative online panel of 1,999 native-born South Koreans fielded through Qualtrics in January 2024. Quotas were set on age, sex, education, and region following the most recent Statistics Korea population parameters. Post-stratification weights were computed by raking on the same dimensions. Appendix A in the Supplementary Information document provides a full sample summary.

Participants were randomly assigned to one of three introductory conditions, illustrated as cards in Figure 2.

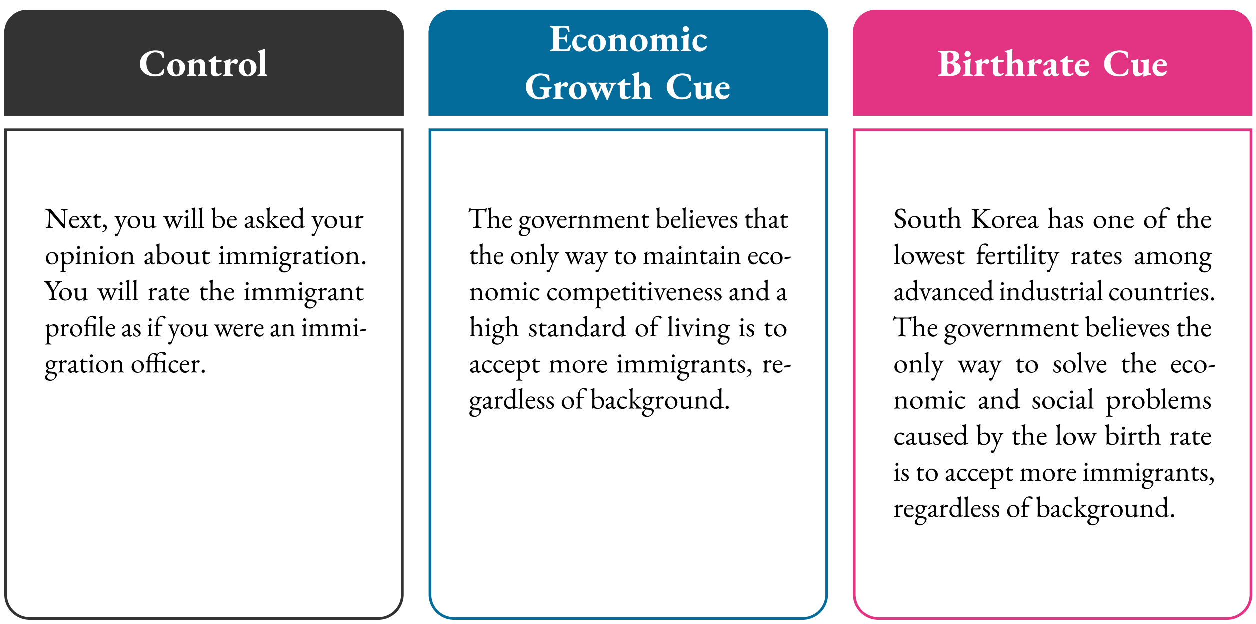

Figure 2: Persuasion-cue intervention in the three between-subjects framing arms.

Note: Verbatim English translations of the Korean prompts. Respondents were assigned to one of the three arms with equal probability at survey entry, with realized per-arm sizes 664 / 637 / 698 in the analytic sample (Control / Growth / Birthrate). The cue is reinforced after the fourth conjoint task to mitigate fade-out.

After exposure to one of the three messages, respondents were asked whether South Korea's immigration levels should be *increased*, *decreased*, or *remain the same*. This single-choice question is the framing-experiment dependent variable. We note that the growth and fertility messages both close with the phrase "regardless of background" (*baegyeong-e gwangyeopsi*). The phrase is intentionally vague and is anti-discrimination in direction. It pushes respondents toward equal treatment across origins. We return to this design property in the discussion of the conjoint results, because it makes the framing manipulation conservative against the origin-discrimination patterns we report.

Arm assignment was concealed by design. The Qualtrics random-integer flow element runs at the start of the survey, and the resulting value is never displayed to the respondent. Respondents are blinded to their condition, with each respondent seeing only the cue text relevant to their arm. The analysts are not blinded, because arm labels appear in the post-fielding data extract. All reported analysis are intention-to-treat. Every randomized respondent is analyzed in their assigned arm regardless of attention-check performance, response time, or any other post-treatment behavior. Attrition by arm is structurally zero in this single-session online design conditional on survey completion. The five respondents dropped between the 2,004 raw finished responses and the 1,999 analytic sample are missing on at least one raking dimension (four on age, one on region), distributed across arms as Control = 2, Growth = 3, Birthrate = 0, and uncorrelated with the framing manipulation, the conjoint task, or the attention check. Appendix A reports per-arm Ns at every flow stage and a balance table across all pre-treatment covariates.

To examine the determinants of admission preferences we used a forced-choice conjoint analysis, a method now standard in immigration-attitude research (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Denney and Green, 2021; Bansak et al., 2016; Fraser and Cheng, 2024). Respondents were asked to imagine themselves as an immigration officer reviewing the profiles of two prospective immigrants and to select the one they believed should be admitted. They evaluated seven paired-profile tasks, choosing between the two profiles in each task. Each profile is randomized along seven attributes: country of origin, ethnicity, occupation, Korean language proficiency, sex, application reason, and employment plan. Table 1 shows the attributes and levels.

Attribute	Levels	Rationale
Country of origin*	United States (ref.) China Philippines Indonesia	Spans cultural, economic, and political distance from the South Korean baseline.
Ethnicity*	Ethnic Korean (ref.) Non-ethnic Korean	Tests the co-ethnic preference and the Overseas Korean Act lineage.
Occupation	Farmer (ref.) Cook Computer engineer Research scientist	Captures the skill premium and the asymmetry between low-skill labour and high-status occupations.
Korean language	Fluent Korean (ref.) Halting Korean No Korean	A core integration signal in South Korean public discourse.
Application reason	Resettlement (ref.) Study Short-term work	Captures the entry-track distinction between permanent settlement, education, and short-term labour.
Employment plan	Contract with Korean employer (ref.) Interviewed, no contract yet Will seek work after arrival No job-seeking plans	Distinguishes labour-market readiness at the point of admission.
Sex	Woman (ref.) Man	Tests gender bias in admission preferences.

Table 1: Conjoint attributes and levels.

Note: Reference levels are marked "(ref.)." Attributes marked with an asterisk (*) are primary quantities of interest. Each respondent evaluated seven paired-profile tasks. The persuasion cue was reinforced after the third task.

The principal quantities of interest are origin and ethnicity, together with their interaction with skill (occupation). Country-of-origin levels span cultural, economic, and political distance. The United States is a high-status, high-income baseline. China is the largest actual immigrant source and politically distant. The Philippines and Indonesia represent the two largest Southeast Asian source countries for documented labour migration to South Korea, with Indonesia further serving as a Muslim-majority comparator. The persuasion cue is reinforced after the third profile to mitigate fade-out of the framing manipulation.

We report two complementary quantities, average marginal component effects (AMCEs) and marginal means (MMs). The AMCE estimates the change in a profile's selection probability when a single attribute changes from a baseline level to a target level, averaging over the joint distribution of the remaining attributes (Hainmueller et al., 2014). The MM reports the average selection probability for a given level. Recent methodological work shows that conditional AMCEs, on which the framing-by-attribute analysis relies, are sensitive to the baseline category and therefore poorly suited for substantive comparisons across subgroups (Leeper et al., 2020; Bansak et al., 2023b). Marginal means are baseline-independent and have a direct probabilistic interpretation. We use AMCEs to characterize main effects relative to a baseline (the United States for origin, Ethnic Korean for ethnicity) and report MMs in parallel for substantive interpretation, particularly for treatment-stratified comparisons. Standard errors are clustered by respondent, and survey weights are applied throughout (Esarey and Menger, 2019).

Appendix D reports the full power and minimum-detectable-effect (MDE) specifications for each estimand class.

4 Findings

Section 4, subsection 4.1, reports policy-preference results by framing arm and by political subgroup. Section 4.2 reports the pooled origin and ethnicity marginal means under each cue and summarizes the matching subgroup analysis, with figures and the full attribute set reported in Appendix C.

The findings depart from a uniform "framing fails on immigration" reading. Pro-immigration framing in this design shifts stated policy preferences but does not decrease the origin- and ethnicity-based discrimination that organizes who respondents would admit. On policy preference, the growth cue *polarizes* along ideological lines, consolidating Maintain in the center and on the right while pushing progressives toward Decrease. On the admission side, the pooled origin penalty against Chinese profiles and the pooled Non-ethnic-Korean penalty hold at the cross-national magnitudes across all three framing arms, and the subgroup cuts by ideology and partisanship (Appendix C) do not overturn this stability.

4.1 The Growth Cue Polarizes Policy Preferences

Figure 3 presents predicted probabilities of support for each immigration-policy option under each framing arm, pooled across ideology. In the control group, 45.4% of respondents favor maintaining current immigration levels, while 38.5% support increases and 16.1% prefer reductions. The growth cue significantly increases support for the status quo by 6.6 percentage points (to 52.0%), drawing primarily from those otherwise inclined toward liberalization, with Increase falling 5.7 points. The fertility cue produces no statistically distinguishable shifts, with support for the status quo rising 1.7 points and Increase falling 2.9 points.

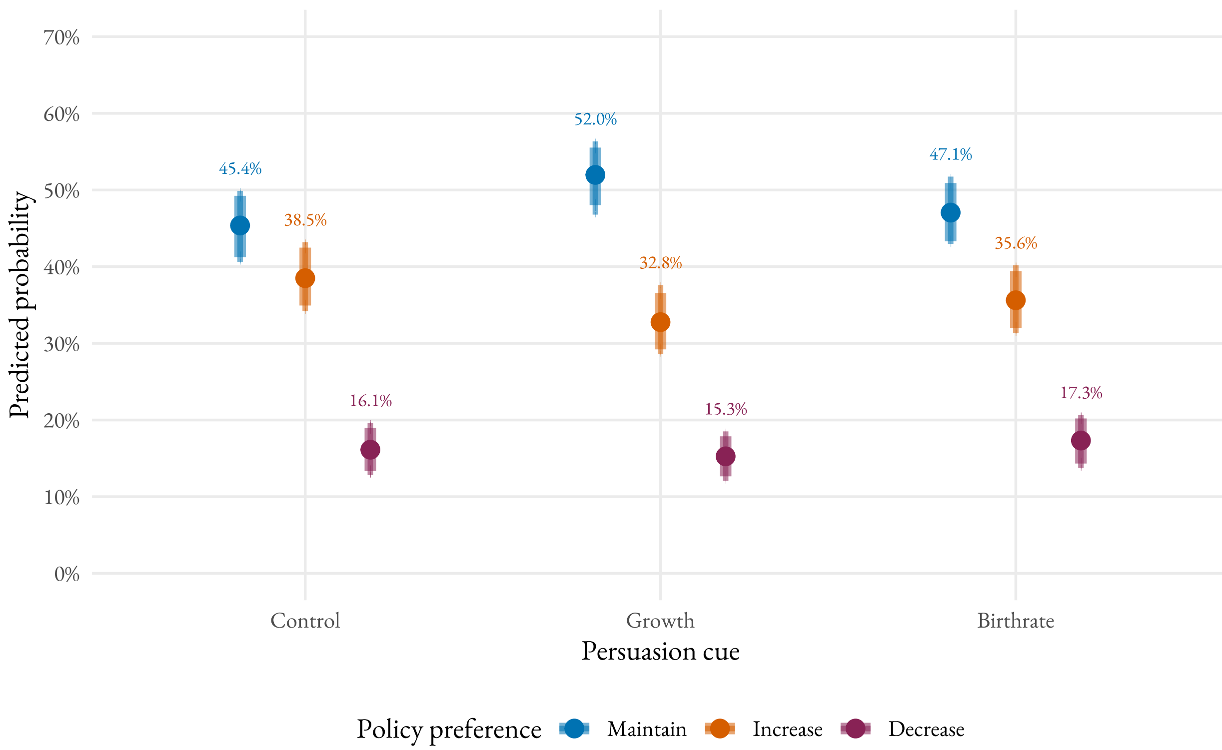

Figure 3: Persuasion cues and immigration-policy preferences (pooled).

Note: Predicted probabilities estimated using multinomial logistic regression with controls for sex, age group, education, region, ideology, and partisanship, and post-stratification survey weights. Error bars show 90% (thick) and 95% (thin) bootstrap confidence intervals. n = 1,996 (model-eligible respondents from the raked sample of 1,999).

The pooled Maintain lift bears directly on the status quo expectation. The subgroup pattern was not specified in advance and is reported as an exploratory but theoretically guided extension.

The pooled estimate, however, conceals a pattern across political subgroups. Figure 4 disaggregates two ways. Panel A shows the cut by self-placed ideology (1-10 scale, collapsed to Progressive, Centrist, and Conservative). Panel B shows the cut by reported party identification (Democratic Party, Independent, People Power Party). The two cuts show related patterns. On the ideology axis, the growth cue produces opposite-direction shifts across the spectrum. Centrists consolidate Maintain by 11.0 points, from 46.0% in the control arm to 57.0% under the growth cue, with Increase falling 8.4 points. Conservatives consolidate Maintain by 11.9 points (40.2% to 52.1%), with Decrease falling 6.4 points. Progressives shift in the opposite direction. Their Maintain share falls 15.7 points (50.6% to 34.9%), and the share selecting Decrease more than doubles, from 9.8% to 22.3%, an absolute shift of 12.5 percentage points among the group that should have been the easiest target for pro-immigration persuasion.

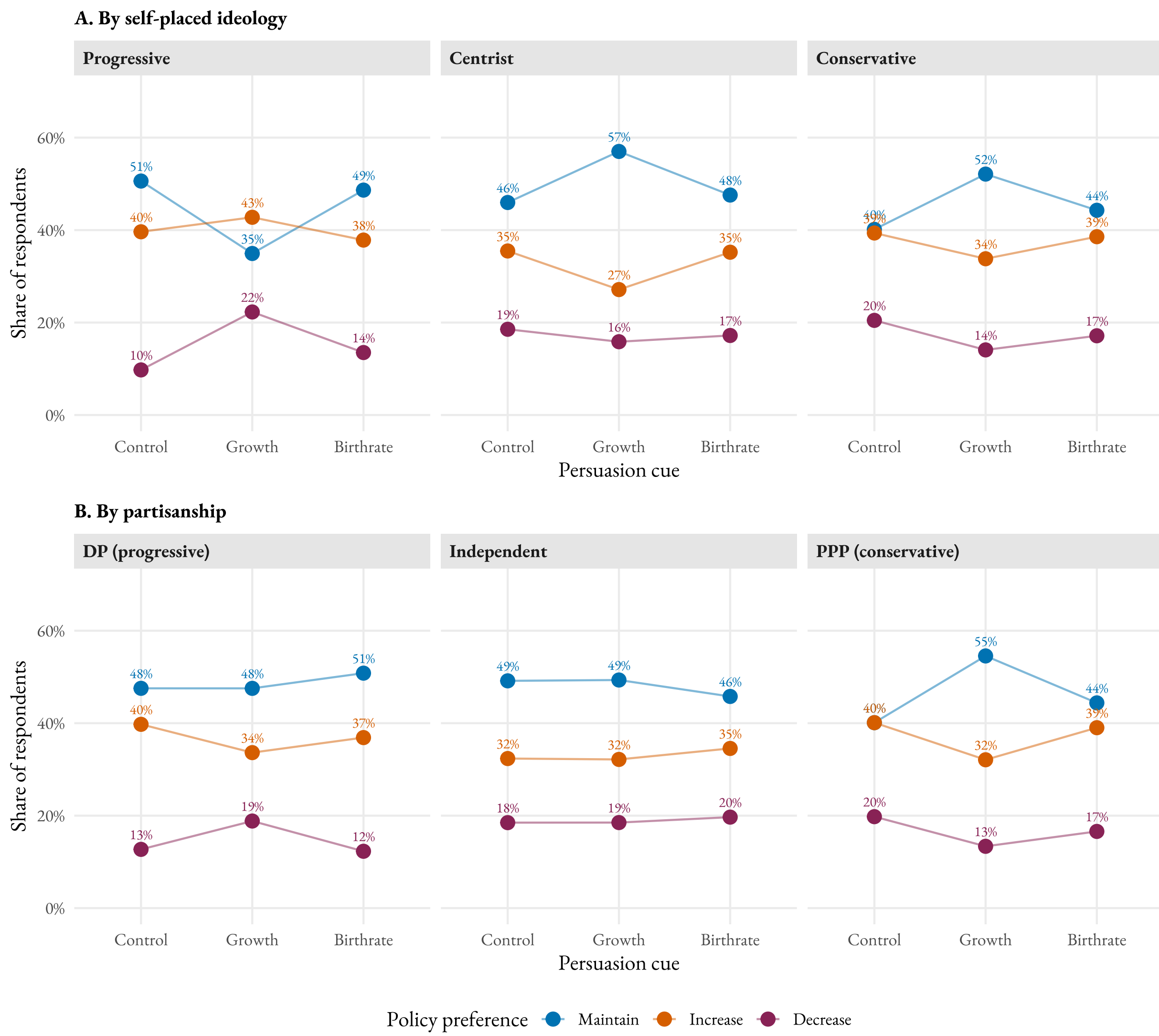

Figure 4: Predicted policy preferences by persuasion cue, disaggregated by political subgroup.

Note: Cell shares within subgroup × frame. Panel A shows ideology measured pre-treatment on a 1-10 self-placement and collapsed to Progressive (1-4), Centrist (5-6), Conservative (7-10). Within-cell n ranges from 127 to 372. Panel B shows partisanship from a pre-treatment item, collapsed to Democratic Party, Independent (DK/Other/Justice-Green), and People Power Party. Within-cell n ranges from 174 to 249. Error bars are 90% (thick) and 95% (thin) confidence intervals with respondent-clustered standard errors and survey weights.

The growth × ideology interactions are statistically detectable. In a linear-probability model with respondent-clustered standard errors and demographic controls, Growth × Centrist on Maintain is +20.6 percentage points (p=.002), and Growth × Conservative on Maintain is +26.2 percentage points (p<.001). Decrease shows the mirror pattern. Growth × Centrist on Decrease is −13.0pp (p=.010). Growth ×

Conservative is -15.2pp (p=.011).

The partisanship cut (Panel B) tracks the ideology pattern only partially. The conservative pole replicates cleanly. PPP identifiers consolidate Maintain by 14 percentage points (40.1% to 54.5%) and reduce Decrease by 6 points, with Growth × PPP on Maintain at +14.0pp (p=.041) and Growth × PPP on Decrease at -11.0pp (p=.036). The progressive pole does not. DP identifiers under the growth cue hold Maintain essentially flat (47.5% to 47.5%) while shifting 6 points from Increase to Decrease. The Maintain decline observed among self-placed progressives is therefore not present among the broader DP coalition. Only the Increase-to-Decrease component of the backlash carries over. We interpret the asymmetry as straightforward measurement. Self-placed Progressives on a 1-10 scale (n = 515) are a smaller, ideologically more activated subset than the DP party-ID coalition (n = 711). The source-cue rejection operates most clearly on respondents whose stated ideology is far enough left to read the executive cue as out-party-aligned. Among more centrist DP identifiers, the cue is closer to neutral and the Maintain share does not collapse. The fertility cue produces no comparable polarization on either cut.

This pattern fits the status quo expectation in one part of the electorate and departs from it in another. Druckman-style persuasion (Expectation 1) predicts liberalization in the cue's argued direction. We instead observe restrictionism among the ideologically nearest group. Kustov-style salience (Expectation 2) predicts a flat directional outcome and is contradicted by the magnitude of the centrist and conservative shifts on Maintain. Status quo activation (Expectation 3) captures the consolidation among centrists and conservatives. The progressive backlash adds a *source-cue* or *elite-consensus rejection* component of the kind documented by Nicholson (2012) and Berinsky (2009), in which an executive-branded message is rejected by partisans of the out-party even when its content matches their priors. The cue's pro-immigration content is consistent with progressive priors, but the cue is also unmistakably the South Korean executive's framing, which Yoon (2022-2025) and Lee (2025-) have both invoked. Progressives reading the cue as a Yoon/Lee-aligned message reject the policy posture over the content.

The polarization pattern is larger than a noise artifact. The growth cue's +20.6pp Growth × Centrist Maintain interaction (Progressive baseline) and the 12.5pp progressive Decrease shift both sit well above the design's minimum detectable interaction effect (see Appendix D). The pooled fertility-cue effects on

Increase, by contrast, are underpowered. The data are consistent with anything from a small liberalizing effect to a small consolidation effect but rule out a large effect in either direction.

For completeness, we also report results by sociotropic baseline orientation (Appendix C, Figure C.1). Among optimists (top quartile of the sociotropic composite, n = 370), the control-arm distribution is 31% Maintain, 63% Increase, 5% Decrease. The growth cue lifts Maintain 13 points and reduces Increase 16 points. Among skeptics (n = 1,006), the cue lifts Maintain 11 points. The pattern qualitatively matches the ideology pattern. The cue consolidates Maintain among groups whose priors are not far from the cue's content. Subgroup interactions with treatment in the multinomial logit are not statistically distinguishable from zero at conventional levels, likely reflecting limited statistical power at the within-arm subgroup sample sizes (optimists at roughly 123 per arm).

4.2 Origin and Ethnicity by Framing Cue

The cross-national conjoint literature on immigrant admissions identifies country of origin and ethnicity as the primary locus of public discrimination over who should be admitted (Bansak et al., 2016; Fraser and Cheng, 2024). The South Korean case has been mapped most directly by Denney and Green (2021), whose forced-choice conjoint on immigrant profiles documents a substantial Chinese-versus-United-States origin penalty alongside a smaller but consistent Non-ethnic-Korean penalty as the two largest ascriptive cleavages in South Korean admission preferences. Because that prior work places origin and ethnicity at the center of South Korean admission preferences, and because the cues we test directly address the demographic-need premise that motivates expanding origin- and ethnicity-restricted visa programs in the South Korean case, we focus the main text on these two attributes. The remaining five attributes in the design form a stable cross-national hierarchy that the framing manipulation does not displace. Appendix C reports them in full.

Figure 5 reports pooled estimates for origin and ethnicity under each framing arm in two panels. Panel A shows AMCEs with the United States and Ethnic Korean categories as the baselines; Panel B shows the corresponding marginal selection probabilities.

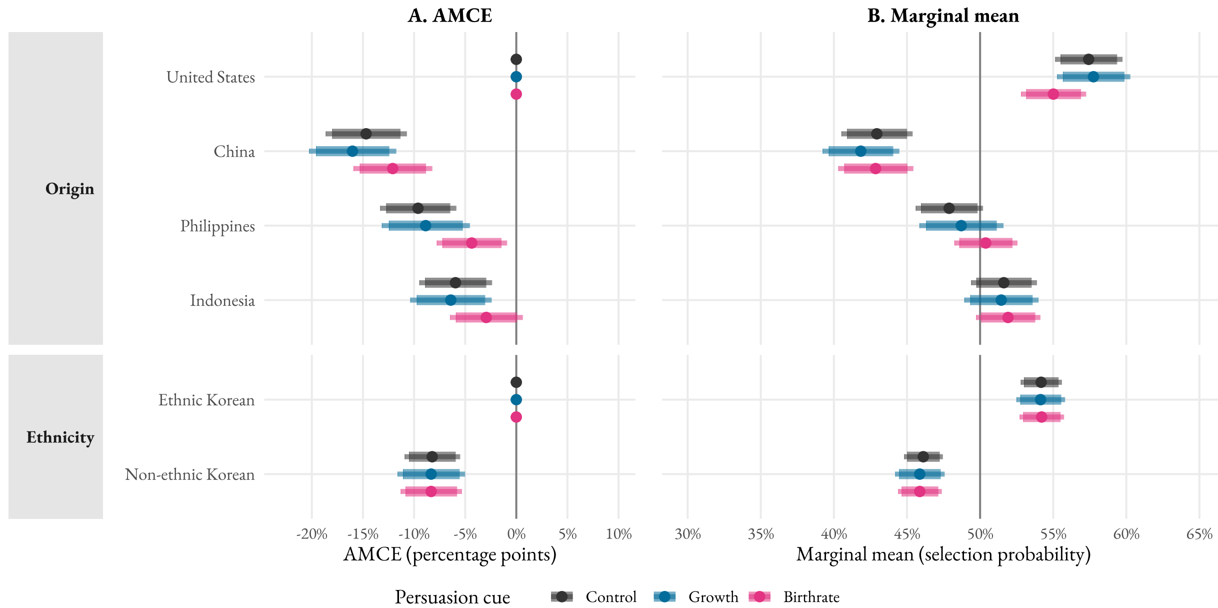

Figure 5: Origin and ethnicity by persuasion cue. Average Marginal Component Effects (Panel A) and marginal means (Panel B).

Note: Panel A reports AMCEs for origin (United States baseline) and ethnicity (Ethnic Korean baseline) under each persuasion cue. Panel B reports the corresponding marginal selection probabilities. Point estimates with respondent-clustered standard errors and survey weights. Thick lines are 90% confidence intervals. Thin lines are 95%. Reference lines at zero (Panel A) and chance selection (Panel B). Sample $n = 1{,}999$.

On origin, the Chinese-versus-United-States penalty is approximately 12 to 16 percentage points across the three arms (14.7pp under Control, 16.0pp under Growth, 12.1pp under Birthrate). The Filipino and Indonesian penalties are smaller and move modestly in the direction of attenuation under the Birthrate cue (Philippines from −9.6pp under Control to −4.4pp under Birthrate; Indonesia from −5.9pp to −2.9pp). The Control-versus-Growth and Control-versus-Birthrate differences on the China penalty sit below the design's minimum detectable treatment-by-origin interaction effect (about 4.9pp; Appendix D). The pooled origin penalty against the politically charged Chinese profile does not move under either cue.

On ethnicity, the Non-ethnic-Korean penalty relative to Ethnic-Korean profiles is essentially flat across arms. It is 8.2pp under Control, 8.3pp under Growth, and 8.3pp under Birthrate. The cues do not reduce the ethnicity penalty.

The cues that shift stated policy preferences (Section 4, subsection 4.1) do not, at the pooled level, decrease the origin- or ethnicity-based discrimination that organizes admission preferences in this design and that the cross-national literature identifies as the primary locus of discrimination in immigration attitudes.

The same conclusion holds at the subgroup level. We disaggregated origin and ethnicity by self-placed ideology and by partisanship using the cuts from Section 4, subsection 4.1, and we examined the cue effects on the remaining substantively-interesting attributes (Korean language, occupation, application reason, employment plan) under the same cuts. None of the subgroup-by-attribute deltas overturn the pooled stability claim.

On origin, progressives show a modest narrowing of the Chinese-versus-United-States gap that is offset by widening on the right and center, so the pooled penalty is unchanged. On ethnicity, the cue effect on the Non-ethnic-Korean penalty is not statistically distinguishable from zero in any subgroup. On the remaining attributes, no systematic subgroup-by-cue interaction emerges. Appendix C reports the figures and the full attribute hierarchy.

5 Conclusion

This study examined whether pro-immigration messages framed around economic growth and demographic decline could shift South Korean attitudes toward immigration policy and toward the origin- and ethnicity-based discrimination that organizes who respondents would admit. The cues shift policy preferences but do not decrease origin- or ethnicity-based discrimination at the admission stage. At the policy level, the growth cue produces ideologically differentiated effects, with centrists and conservatives consolidating the status quo and self-placed progressives shifting toward restriction. At the admission level, the pooled Chinese-versus-United-States penalty and the Non-ethnic-Korean penalty are essentially unchanged across framing arms. Within-subgroup variation on the origin penalty cancels in aggregate. The ethnicity penalty is unmoved in every subgroup we examine.

The growth cue raises support for maintaining current immigration levels in the population average, but this average masks opposite-direction movement across ideological groups. Centrists and conservatives consolidate around Maintain, while self-placed progressives shift toward *Decrease*. The pattern is clearer on the ideology cut than on partisanship, where the conservative side replicates the consolidation and the progressive side shows only part of the restrictionist movement. Section 4 reports the magnitudes. We read the cleaner ideology pattern as consistent with status quo activation among respondents whose priors are broadly compatible with the executive's sociotropic argument, alongside a source-cue reaction among respondents who read the message as out-party-aligned. We treat this as suggestive evidence on the source-cue mechanism.

On the admission side, the pooled origin and ethnicity penalties are unchanged across arms within the design's minimum detectable interaction effect (Appendix D). Within-subgroup variation on origin (a modest narrowing among progressives, a widening among centrists, conservatives, Independents, and People Power Party identifiers, with the largest widening on the People Power Party side; Appendix C) cancels in aggregate. The cue effect on the ethnicity penalty is not statistically distinguishable from zero in any subgroup. The cues that shift stated policy preferences do not decrease the origin- or ethnicity-based discrimination the cross-national literature (Bansak et al., 2016; Denney and Green, 2021; Fraser and Cheng, 2024) identifies as the primary locus of discrimination in immigration attitudes. The remaining five attributes operate at the cross-national magnitudes and are reported in the Supplementary Information.

Theoretically, the findings contribute to debates about persuasion and prejudice in two related directions. They identify a boundary condition on the parallel-updating consensus. In a setting where ethnocultural priors are strong and demographic need is severe, pro-immigration framing appears to activate the status quo among respondents whose priors are compatible with the executive cue and to invite a source-cue reaction among those who read the message through out-party politics. The findings also specify a separation between the policy and individual levels at which respondents process immigration cues. The framing manipulation shifts what respondents say they want as a quantity. It leaves candidate sorting largely unchanged. This complicates both the Kustov salience-not-direction account (Kustov, 2024) and the standard "no effect" reading of immigration framing nulls, and it suggests that future work should specify which level a cue is expected to operate on before testing it.

Our framing manipulation is a single-paragraph cue rather than a full media-environment manipulation, so effect sizes are bounded by the strength of the cue. The differentiated patterns we report emerge inside this single-paragraph cue, and the comparative literature suggests that real-world media-environment manipulation should amplify them. The modest Birthrate-cue narrowing of the Filipino and Indonesian penalties is an interesting next target. A design built specifically to test whether a fertility frame relaxes admission preferences over candidates from Southeast Asian source countries that South Korean labour-immigration policy already privileges, with a larger sample on the cells in question and an a priori restriction to that attribute family, would establish whether the small pooled deltas we observe are a substantive cue effect or noise. An additional avenue for future research concerns the intersection of demographic decline, national security, and immigration. In South Korea, population aging and low fertility are also security concerns in a state that maintains compulsory military service under persistent threat from North Korea. Whether security-oriented cues, linking immigration to sustaining national defence capacity, affect public opinion in similarly polarizing ways is an important extension our design does not address (Bigo, 2002).

Several further limitations frame the inferences we draw. The study is a single country, single fielding (January 2024), and a panel-based online sample fielded through Qualtrics. Generalization across countries with different ethnonational baselines, across panel and probability samples, and across time, including post-2024 changes in partisan composition, requires replication. The two cues we test are the ones the South Korean government has actually advanced in published policy documents, a strength for external validity and a constraint on generalizability. Other plausible cues, such as a security frame, a humanitarian frame, or an economic-redistribution frame, are absent from the design and may produce different patterns.

6 Policy Implications

Two implications for policy and political communication follow from the findings. First, in elite-consensus contexts where pro-immigration framing is already the official line, generic sociotropic messaging can consolidate the status quo among groups whose priors are compatible with the executive cue while producing differentiated responses among groups that read the message through out-party politics. The growth cue's progressive reaction is a cautionary case for governments considering a national pro-immigration campaign keyed to growth or fertility. Specific arguments tied to identifiable beneficiaries, and source-diverse delivery rather than executive-branded messaging, appear in the comparative literature to be more effective for moving stated policy preferences in the cue's argued direction (Kustov, 2024; Hopkins et al., 2026; Nicholson, 2012).

Second, the conjoint-stability result suggests that pro-immigration cues of the kind tested here operate on stated policy posture rather than on the underlying criteria respondents apply to immigrant profiles. Even where stated policy preferences shift, the origin penalty against Chinese profiles and the penalty against non-ethnic-Korean profiles remain in place at the magnitudes the cross-national literature documents. For policymakers, this implies that headline shifts in survey support for "more" or "less" immigration do not translate into broader public openness on *which* immigrants would be admitted. Reform efforts that depend on relaxing the origin- and ethnicity-based hierarchies documented in the South Korean and broader East Asian cases require interventions that target those hierarchies directly, rather than relying on general pro-immigration framing to do that work.

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Supplementary Information for "Persuasion and Prejudice: Are South Korean Attitudes Toward Immigration Open to Change?"

Appendix A Additional Survey Information

The survey was fielded through Qualtrics' online panel in January 2024, recording responses from 2,004 native-born South Koreans (1,999 after excluding respondents missing on raking dimensions). To ensure semi-representativeness, quotas were established in alignment with the most up-to-date demographic parameters from Statistics Korea (KOSIS, January 2024). The design included Qualtrics' inbuilt quality controls (bot and duplicate detection), a Korean-citizen screen (Q6), and a manual attention check (Q7, "Please select strongly disagree"). Respondents who failed any of these checks exited the survey at the corresponding flow branch and were replaced through additional fielding. All replacement and quality-flag review occurred *before* the framing manipulation block in the Qualtrics flow. The citizen screen and the attention check sit on branches that terminate the response prior to the cue presentation, so no respondent who saw a framing cue was replaced post hoc. The 2,004 finished responses entering our analysis therefore all received a frame assignment and proceeded through every downstream block. To correct for over- and under-sampling, especially for education, we added post-stratification weights using the raking method (`survey` package in R) on age group, sex, education, and a five-category region (collapsing the seventeen administrative districts to capital, capital region, southeast, southwest, and other). Table A.1 reports unweighted sample counts and weighted proportions.

Variable	Count	Proportion	Weighted Prop.
Age			
18-29	357	17.9%	17.5%
30-39	348	17.4%	15.7%
40-49	397	19.9%	16.6%
50-59	529	26.5%	21.5%
60+	369	18.4%	28.6%
Sex			
Man	1,015	50.7%	50.0%
Woman	989	49.3%	50.0%
Education			
No University	388	19.4%	45.5%
University	1,616	80.6%	54.5%
Region (collapsed)			
Capital (Seoul)	873	43.7%	29.5%
Capital region (Gyeonggi, Incheon)	555	27.8%	20.9%
Southeast (Gyeongsang, Busan, Daegu, Ulsan)	264	13.2%	23.1%
Southwest (Jeolla, Gwangju)	103	5.2%	11.7%
Other (Chungcheong, Gangwon, Daejeon, Sejong, Jeju)	208	10.4%	14.8%

Table A.1: Summary counts, proportions, and weighted proportions for South Korea. Counts and unweighted proportions are reported on the raw sample (n = 2,004 before exclusions for missing raking variables). Weighted proportions are computed on the analytic sample of n = 1,999. Small row-total deviations (age = 2,000, sex = 2,004) reflect item-level missingness on the demographic items and the raking-exclusion difference.

Sample derivation and participant flow

Frame assignment in the Qualtrics flow is implemented as an unconstrained uniform random integer drawn at survey entry (`RandomImmIntro = ${rand://int/1:3}`, FlowID FL_6), so eligibility, consent, and quality-assurance branches run on already-randomized respondents. Because the citizen screen, the attention check, and the bot and duplicate-detection branches all terminate the response *before* the framing manipulation block (FlowID FL_19), respondents removed at these checkpoints never reached a cue and were replaced through additional fielding rather than carried forward. The 2,004 finished responses in the export therefore correspond to respondents who passed all upstream quality controls and proceeded through every downstream block. The per-arm Ns at each stage of sample construction are listed below.

- Eligibility assessment covered 2,004 native-born Korean respondents who reached the framing block after passing Qualtrics screening and consent (upstream replacement of failed quality flags handled at fielding, not tracked at the respondent level in the export).
- Pre-randomization exclusions were 0. The random integer is assigned at survey entry. The upstream quality, citizen, and attention-check branches eliminate failing responses before the cue is presented, and those responses are replaced rather than reported.
- Random assignment covered 2,004 respondents total. Control = 666, Growth = 640, Birthrate (Fertility) = 698.
- The intended condition was received by 2,004 respondents, identical to the randomized count. The cue is a text screen presented immediately after assignment, so compliance loss is structurally zero in this online single-session design.
- Loss to follow-up was 0 in the single-session online survey with no inter-session continuation.
- Post-randomization exclusions were 5 total. Control = 2, Growth = 3, Birthrate = 0. All five drops are due to item-level missingness on one or more raking dimensions (four on age, one on region). None are due to the framing manipulation, the conjoint task, the attention check, or any post-treatment behavior.
- The framing experiment ITT analysis includes 1,999 respondents total. Control = 664, Growth = 637, Birthrate = 698. The same n = 1,999 enters the conjoint analysis, with profile-level rows clustered on respondent.

Baseline balance across framing arms

Table A.2 reports pre-treatment covariate distributions stratified by framing arm, together with the maximum pairwise standardized mean difference (SMD) across the three arm-pairs for each covariate. Continuous covariates use a pooled-SD denominator. Binary indicators use $\sqrt{p_{\text{pool}}(1-p_{\text{pool}})}$. Demographic balance is strong across age, sex, education, ideology, partisanship, and the pre-treatment sociotropic composite (all SMDs ≤ 0.09). The single covariate that exceeds the 0.10 balance threshold is the Southeast region (SMD = 0.16, with 11.0% Control, 16.5% Growth, 12.3% Birthrate), which falls within the variance expected from unconstrained random-integer assignment at n ≈ 660 per arm and below the conventional 0.20 imbalance flag. The headline framing-experiment models in the main text condition on age group, sex, education, region, ideology, and partisanship, so the small Southeast imbalance is also adjusted away in estimation.

Covariate	Control	Growth	Birthrate	Max SMD
N (analyzed)	664	637	698	–
Age, mean (SD)	45.8 (14.5)	45.4 (14.6)	45.6 (14.6)	0.030
Female (%)	50.2%	48.8%	48.7%	0.029
University (%)	79.8%	80.2%	81.8%	0.050
Region (5-category collapse)				
Capital (Seoul)	46.4%	41.9%	42.3%	0.090
Capital region (Gyeonggi, Incheon)	28.2%	26.4%	28.5%	0.048
Southeast	11.0%	16.5%	12.3%	0.160
Southwest	5.3%	4.9%	5.3%	0.020
Other	9.2%	10.4%	11.6%	0.079
Ideology (1–10), mean (SD)	5.2 (1.8)	5.3 (1.9)	5.2 (1.8)	0.058
Partisanship				
Democratic Party (DP, %)	36.7%	35.0%	35.0%	0.037
People Power Party (PPP, %)	27.4%	29.4%	29.4%	0.043
Independent / Other (%)	35.8%	35.6%	35.7%	0.004
Sociotropic composite (1–7), mean (SD)	4.5 (1.1)	4.4 (1.1)	4.5 (1.1)	0.030

Table A.2: Pre-treatment covariate balance across framing arms. The SMD column reports the maximum pairwise standardized mean difference across the three arm-pairs. Continuous variables use a pooled-SD denominator; binary indicators use $\sqrt{p_{\text{pool}}(1-p_{\text{pool}})}$. Values < 0.10 conventionally indicate balance; values ≥ 0.20 flag imbalance.

Appendix B Survey Questions

This section provides the text used for the background questions, the policy-preference dependent variable, the sociotropic battery, and the framing-cue messages.

Background Questions

- Sex at birth was recorded as Male / Female.
- Current residence was recorded as one of seventeen administrative regions.
- Age was recorded as a validated numeric input.
- Highest level of education was recorded as No formal / Elementary or below / Middle school / High school / Some college / University / Graduate / Other.
- Ideology was recorded on a 1-10 sliding scale (1 = very progressive, 10 = very conservative).
- Party preference was recorded for a hypothetical national election tomorrow as People Power Party / Minjoo Party / Green-Justice Party / Other Party / Don't know.

Sociotropic-Attitude Battery

The six-item battery used this prompt. "Please rate how much you agree with the following items (1 = strongly agree, 4 = neutral, 7 = strongly disagree)."

- The influx of foreign workers increases the competitiveness of the domestic agricultural industry.
- The influx of foreign workers financially secures pensions, stabilizes the population, and increases birth rates.
- The influx of foreign workers increases the competitiveness of the domestic financial sector.
- The influx of foreign workers is beneficial to Korea.
- The influx of foreign workers increases the competitiveness of domestic manufacturing.

- The influx of foreign workers is essential to domestic economic growth.

We reverse-code the items so that higher composite scores indicate more pro-immigration sentiment. Sociotropic optimists are coded as the top quartile of the composite (75th percentile cut, n = 370). The rest are skeptics (n = 1,006).

Framing Cue Messages

The following messages are verbatim from the instrument.

- *Control*: "Next, you will be asked your opinion about immigration. You will rate the immigrant profile as if you were an immigration officer."
- *Economic Growth Cue*: "The government believes that the only way to maintain economic competitiveness and a high standard of living is to accept more immigrants, regardless of their background. Next, you'll be asked for your opinion on immigration. You will rate immigrant profiles as if you were an immigration officer."
- *Birthrate Cue*: "South Korea has one of the lowest fertility rates among advanced industrialized countries. The government believes that the only way to solve the economic and social problems caused by the low birth rate is to accept more immigrants, regardless of their background. Next, you will be asked for your opinion on immigration. You will rate immigrant profiles as if you were an immigration officer."

The cue is reinforced after the fourth conjoint task with a shortened "Remember, the government believes …" restatement.

Policy-Preference DV

The single-choice item asked, "In your view, should immigration levels be maintained at current levels, increased, or decreased?"

Conjoint Task Instructions

Verbatim English translation. “To pilot a new policy, the immigration office is reviewing applications from legal residents. You have been assigned to review applications under this pilot. You will see profiles of two immigrants who came to Korea. Of these two, please select the one you think is more suitable to be admitted.”

Appendix C Additional Figures and Tables

This section presents supplementary figures and tables underlying the policy-preference and origin/ethnicity findings reported in the main text (Sections 4.1-4.3), along with the full conjoint attribute hierarchy that the main text leaves to the SI.

Figure C.1 reports policy-preference subgroup results by sociotropic baseline orientation (optimists vs. skeptics). The growth cue produces a large consolidation effect in both groups. The fertility cue produces small shifts.

Figure C.2 presents marginal means for all conjoint attributes pooled across framing arms. The main text focuses on origin and ethnicity because the comparative literature (Bansak et al., 2016; Denney and Green, 2021; Fraser and Cheng, 2024) identifies these as the primary discriminatory attributes in immigrant admission preferences. The other attributes form a stable cross-national hierarchy that the framing manipulation does not displace.

Two attributes carry the largest variation in selection probability. Employment plan spans a 26.8-percentage-point range, from *No job-seeking plans* at 34.2% to *Contract with Korean employer* at 61.0%. Korean-language fluency spans 21.6 points, from *No Korean* at 39.2% to *Fluent Korean* at 60.8%. Country of origin spans 14.2 points, with China at 42.5% and the United States at 56.7%. The next four attributes carry smaller but non-trivial ranges. Occupation spans 9.7pp (Research scientist at 55.4% above Cook at 45.8%), application reason 8.8pp (Resettlement above Short-term work), ethnicity 8.2pp (Ethnic Korean vs. Non-ethnic Korean), and profile sex 2.4pp. Korean fluency on its own is large enough to override origin. A Fluent-Korean Chinese profile is selected at well above the chance line, beating a No-Korean American profile.

Two substantive points follow. The dominant attribute pattern is integrationist rather than ascriptive: acquired civic and labour-market markers (employment plan, language, occupation) carry as much or more weight than the unalterable ones (origin, ethnicity). And among the unalterable attributes, origin carries the largest individual penalty (China at -14.2pp pooled), although the prior literature on hierarchical nationhood would predict the ethnic-Korean vs. non-ethnic-Korean penalty to dominate at the public-attitude level (Seol and Skrentny, 2009; Denney and Green, 2021).

Across the framing arms, the headline attribute hierarchies are stable. The No-Korean penalty (about 22 points relative to fluent), the No-job-seeking-plans penalty (about 27 points relative to a confirmed contract), and the China penalty (about 14 points relative to the United States) operate at the same magnitudes under every cue. Cue effects on the pooled origin and ethnicity marginal means change by no more than 3 percentage points, below the design's MDE for treatment-by-attribute interactions (Appendix D reports the MDE at about 4.9pp).

Tables C.1, C.2, and C.3 report regression-based estimates underlying the framing-experiment and origin-by-frame analyses in the main text.

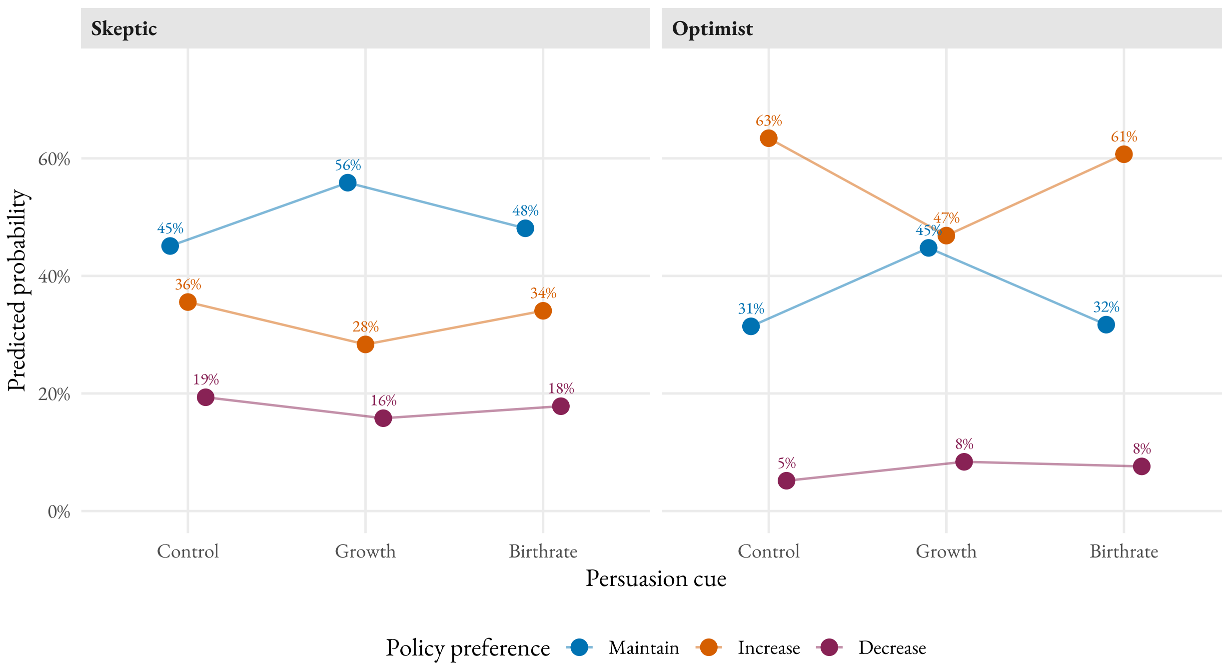

Figure C.1: Persuasion cues and immigration policy preferences, by sociotropic baseline orientation.

Note: Predicted probabilities from multinomial logistic regression with controls and survey weights. Optimists are the top quartile of the pre-treatment sociotropic composite (75th percentile cut). Skeptics are the rest. Within-arm n is optimists ≈ 110-130 and skeptics ≈ 230-260.

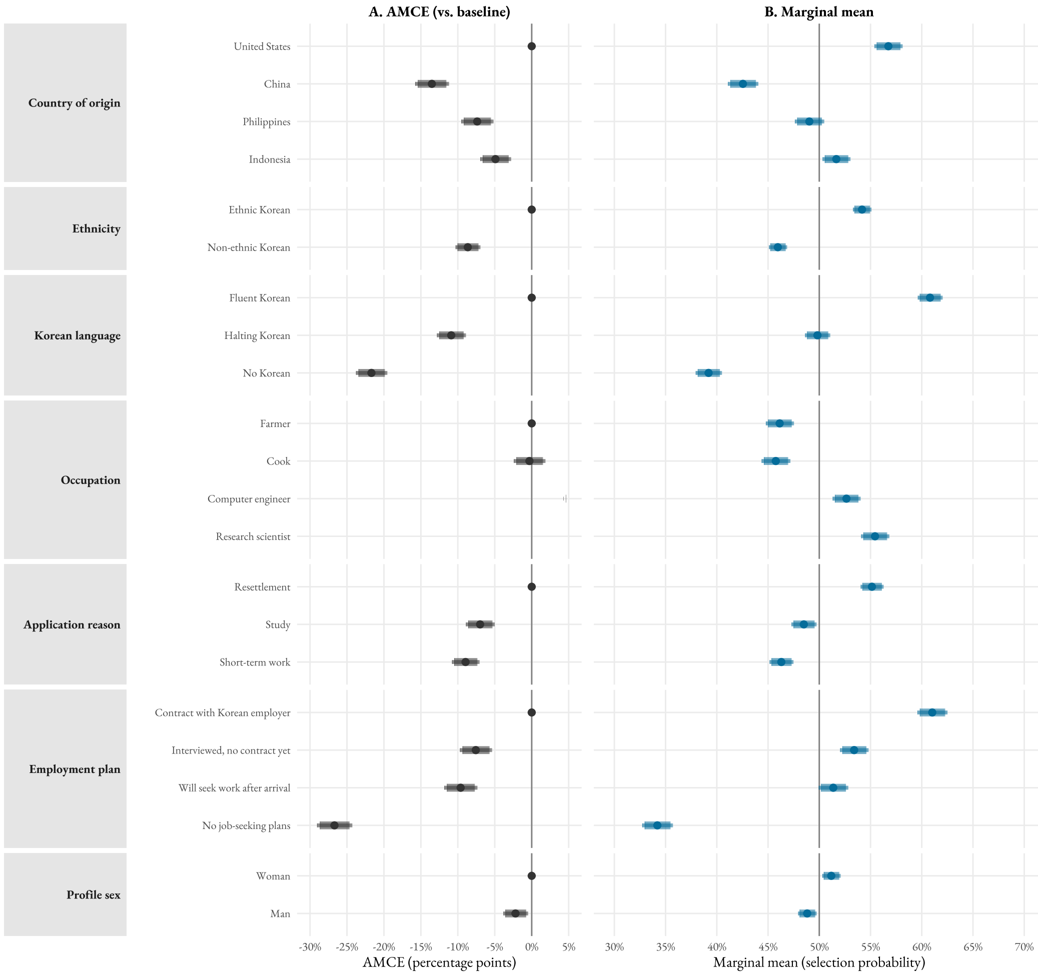

Figure C.2: Full attribute hierarchy of the Immigration CBC. AMCEs (Panel A) and marginal means (Panel B), pooled across framing arms.

Note: Panel A reports AMCEs against the reference level for each of the seven attributes in the forced-choice conjoint described in Table **??**. Panel B reports the corresponding marginal selection probabilities for each level. Analytic sample $n = 1{,}999$ from the January 2024 fielding. The vertical reference line is zero in Panel A and 0.5 (chance selection) in Panel B. Thick lines are 90% confidence intervals. Thin lines are 95%.

Origin and ethnicity by ideology and partisanship

The main text reports a pooled finding that the framing cues do not move the origin or ethnicity penalty. Figures C.3 and C.4 report the same two attributes disaggregated by self-placed ideology and by reported partisanship, respectively. Each figure stacks origin (Panel A) above ethnicity (Panel B). On origin, progressives show modest narrowing of the Chinese-versus-United-States gap under both cues; centrists, conservatives, Independents, and People Power Party identifiers show widening of the same gap under one or both cues. People Power Party identifiers show the largest individual widening, with the Chinese penalty moving from about 14 percentage points under Control to about 18 under each cue. Across the six subgroup panels the narrowing on the ideological left is offset by widening on the right and center, producing the pooled stability reported in the main text. On ethnicity, the Non-ethnic-Korean penalty changes by no more than two to three percentage points across arms in any subgroup, and the changes are not statistically distinguishable from zero. The smallest cells (Conservative under each cue, $n \approx 127$-142) carry wide confidence intervals; the subgroup point estimates should not be over-read in either direction.

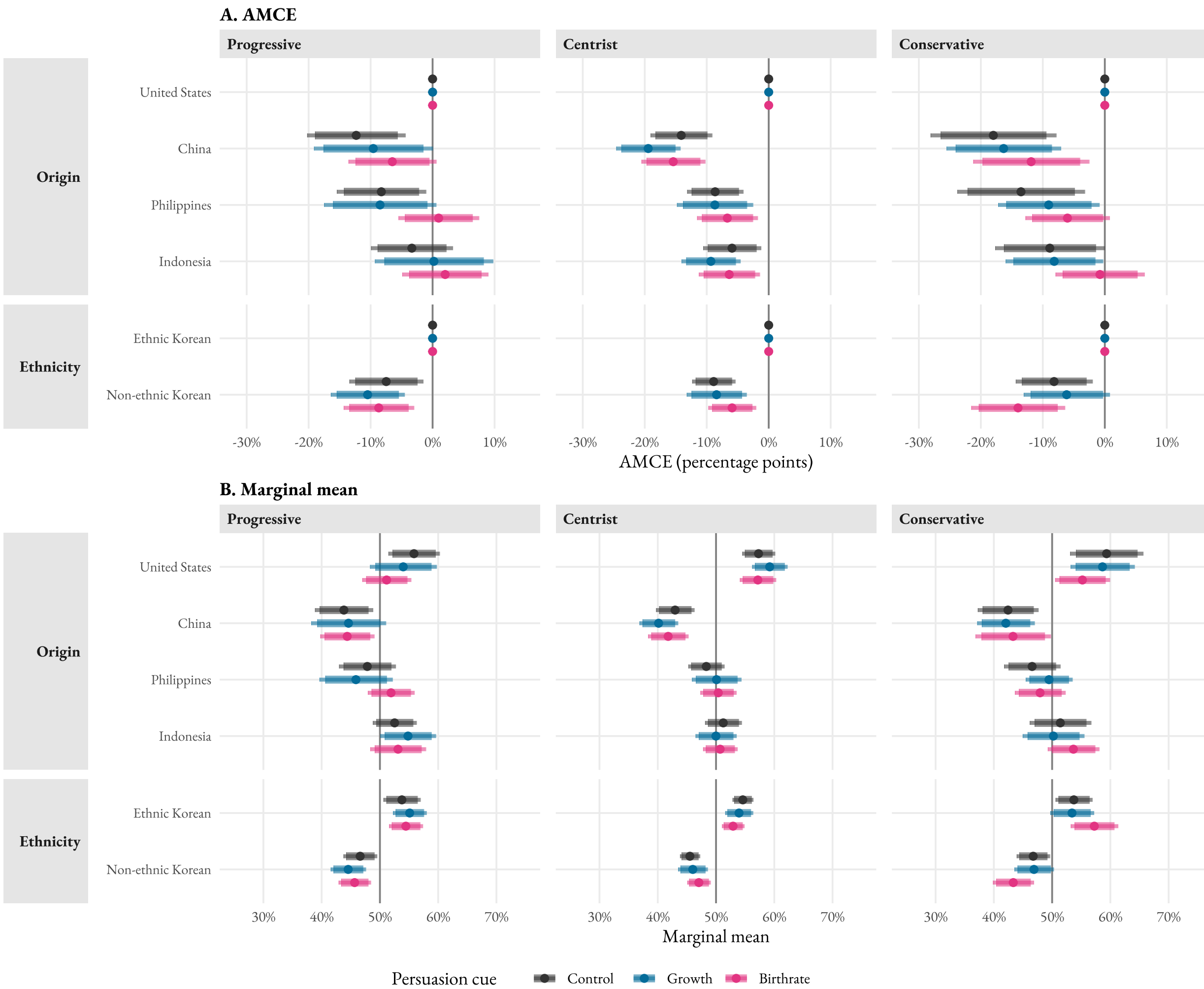

Figure C.3: Origin and ethnicity by persuasion cue, by self-placed ideology. AMCEs (Panel A) and marginal means (Panel B).

Note: Panel A reports AMCEs for origin (United States baseline) and ethnicity (Ethnic Korean baseline) under each persuasion cue, separately for each ideology subgroup. Panel B reports the corresponding marginal selection probabilities. Per-cell respondent N: 127-372 (Appendix D). Thick lines are 90% confidence intervals. Thin lines are 95%. Reference lines at zero (Panel A) and chance selection (Panel B).

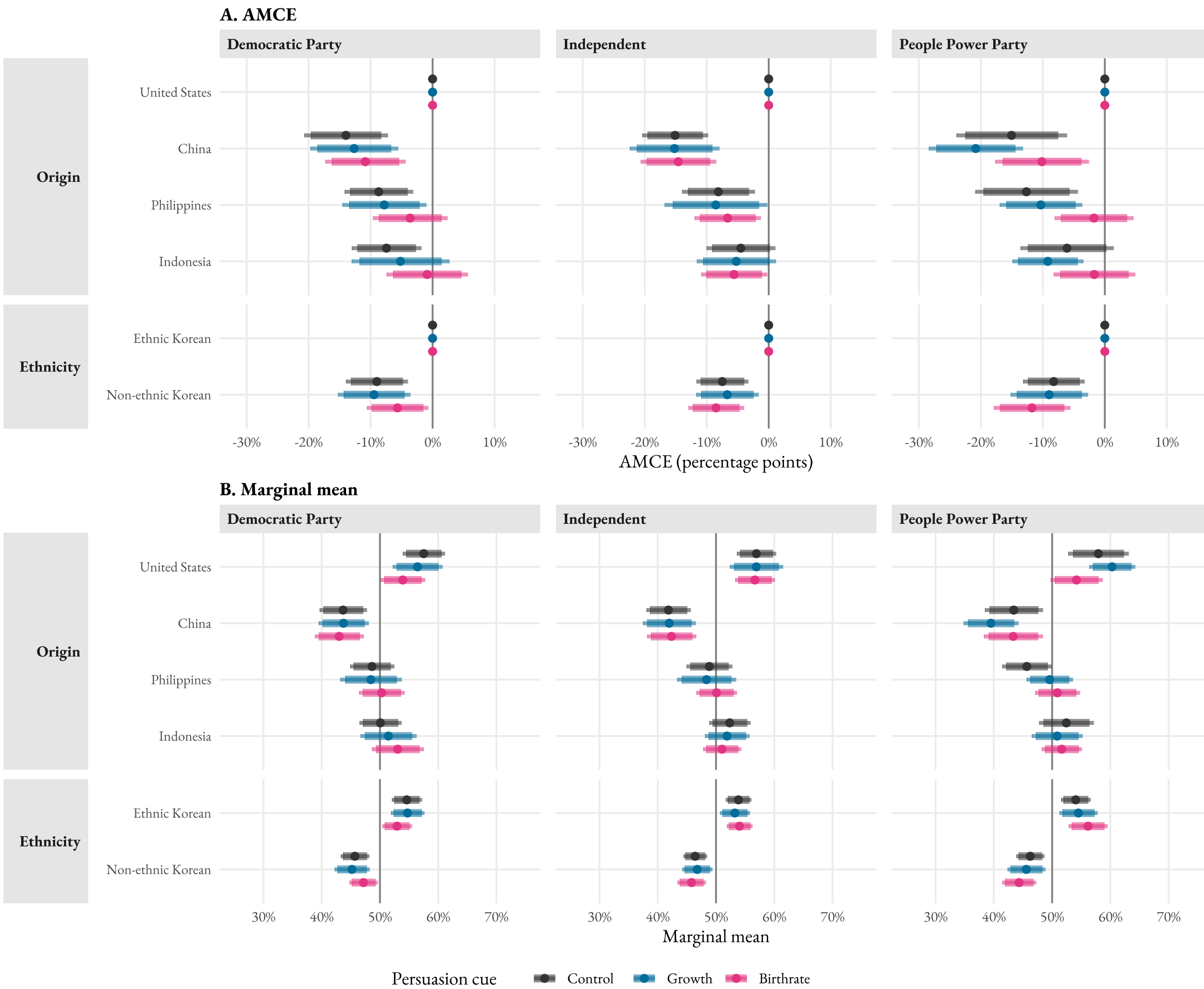

Figure C.4: Origin and ethnicity by persuasion cue, by partisanship. AMCEs (Panel A) and marginal means (Panel B).

Note: Same layout as Figure C.3, with reported partisanship as the cut variable (Democratic Party, Independent, People Power Party). Per-cell respondent N: 182-249 (Appendix D). Thick lines are 90% confidence intervals; thin lines are 95%.

Cue effects on the other substantively-interesting attributes by subgroup

Figures C.5 and C.6 extend the subgroup analysis to the remaining substantively-interesting attributes (Korean language, occupation, application reason, employment plan). Each figure reports the Growth−Control and Birthrate−Control deltas in marginal selection probability for every attribute level, faceted by the relevant subgroup cut. Most cue effects cluster within ± 3 percentage points of zero across attributes and subgroups. None of the subgroup-by-attribute deltas overturn the pooled stability claim reported in the main text.

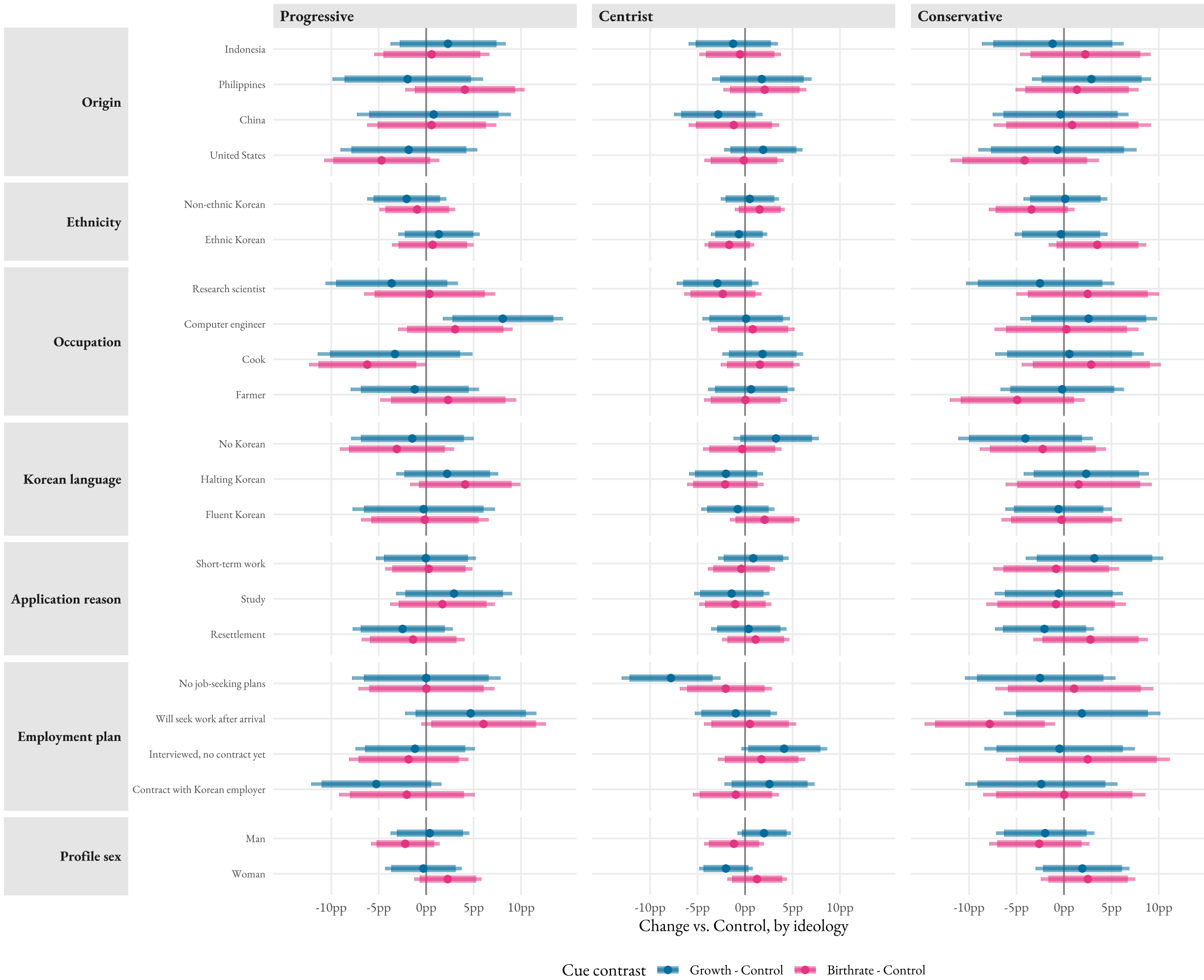

Figure C.5: Cue effects on marginal means across all attributes, by self-placed ideology.

Note: Each point shows the change in the marginal selection probability for a given attribute level under the named cue relative to Control, within the ideological subgroup. Blue: Growth−Control. Pink: Birthrate−Control. No statistical significance markers are added because the figure summarizes descriptive deltas across many cells; for the headline origin and ethnicity comparisons see Figure C.3 and the main text.

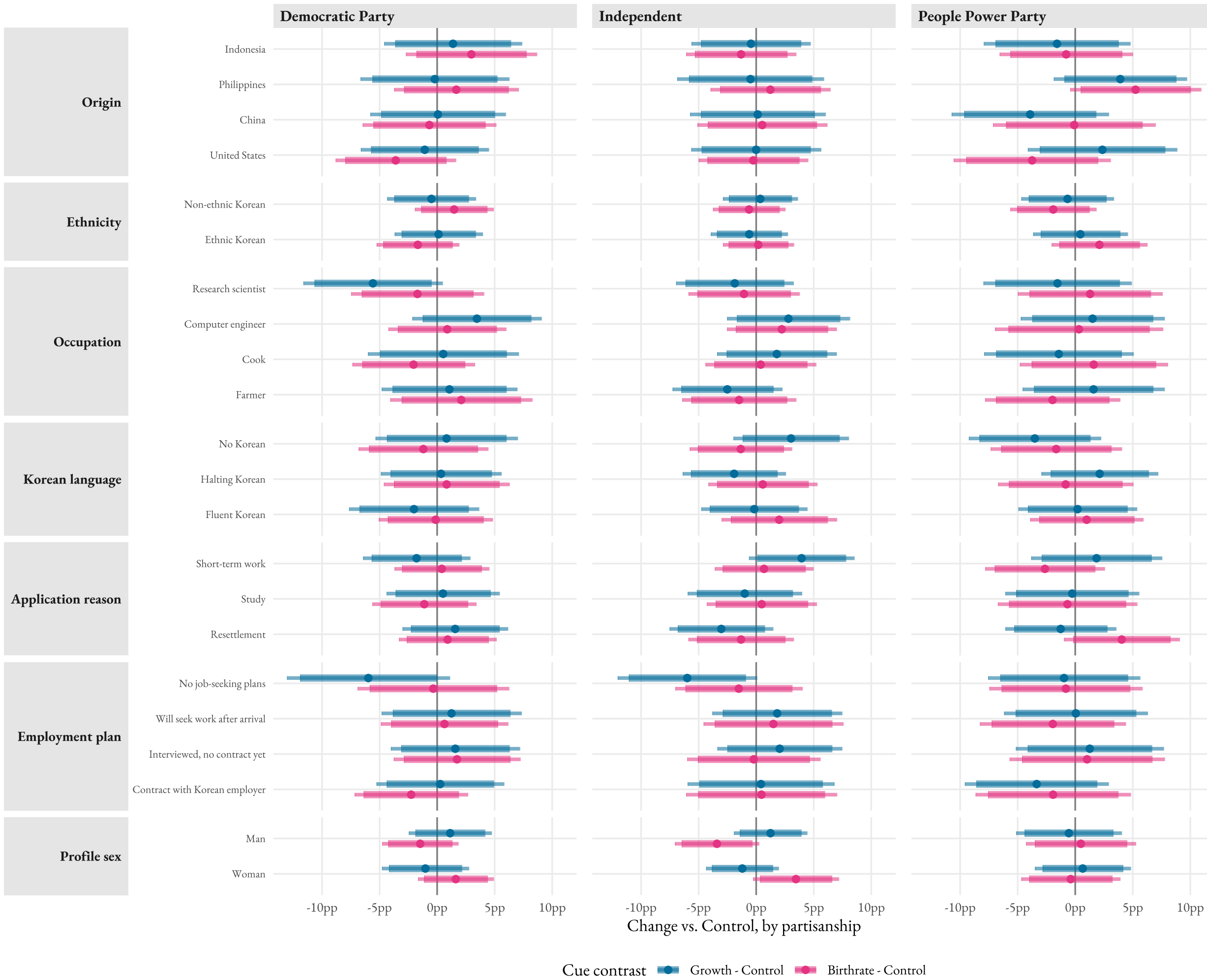

Figure C.6: Cue effects on marginal means across all attributes, by partisanship.

Note: Same layout as Figure C.5, with partisanship as the cut variable.

Outcome	Term	Estimate	SE	z	p
Decrease	frameBirthrate	0.0365	0.1553	0.235	0.8142
Decrease	frameGrowth	-0.1952	0.1590	-1.228	0.2196
Increase	frameBirthrate	-0.1216	0.1265	-0.961	0.3367
Increase	frameGrowth	-0.3131	0.1282	-2.442	0.0146

Table C.1: Multinomial logit treatment coefficients (relative to Maintain baseline). Controls: sex, age group, education, region, ideology, partisanship. Survey weights applied; cluster-robust SEs.

Variable	Estimate	SE	z-statistic	p-value
Support Increase				
Birthrate Cue	-0.0569	0.1484	-0.383	0.7015
Growth Cue	-0.1413	0.1533	-0.922	0.3566
Sociotropic Optimists	1.2567	0.1845	6.811	< 0.0001
Growth Cue × Optimists	-0.1769	0.2612	-0.677	0.4983
Birthrate Cue × Optimists	0.0972	0.2651	0.367	0.7139
Support Decrease				
Birthrate Cue	0.0615	0.1542	0.399	0.6900
Growth Cue	-0.1285	0.1610	-0.798	0.4248
Sociotropic Optimists	-1.4836	0.3140	-4.726	< 0.0001
Growth Cue × Optimists	-0.1637	0.4810	-0.340	0.7337
Birthrate Cue × Optimists	-0.8832	0.5782	-1.528	0.1265
Support Maintain				
Birthrate Cue	0.0017	0.1300	0.013	0.9896
Growth Cue	0.1936	0.1332	1.453	0.1463
Sociotropic Optimists	-0.5354	0.1804	-2.967	0.0030
Growth Cue × Optimists	0.2004	0.2519	0.796	0.4262
Birthrate Cue × Optimists	0.0760	0.2581	0.294	0.7686

Table C.2: Multinomial logit treatment effects by sociotropic orientation

Note: Reference categories are Control treatment and Sociotropic Skeptics. Survey weights applied. Cluster-robust SEs.

Treatment Contrast	Origin Contrast	Estimate	SE	t-statistic	p-value
Growth − Control					
Growth − Control	China − USA	-0.014	0.030	-0.48	0.629
Growth − Control	Philippines − USA	0.005	0.029	0.17	0.864
Growth − Control	Indonesia − USA	-0.005	0.027	-0.19	0.853
Birthrate − Control					
Birthrate − Control	China − USA	0.023	0.028	0.83	0.410
Birthrate − Control	Philippines − USA	0.049	0.026	1.89	0.059
Birthrate − Control	Indonesia − USA	0.027	0.026	1.05	0.294

Table C.3: Treatment × Origin AMCE differences (Cue − Control), pooled.

Note: AMCE differences for each origin relative to USA, computed as (Cue - Control). Weighted OLS with respondent-clustered SEs.

Appendix D Power, Minimum Detectable Effect, and Equivalence Tests

The achieved sample is n = 1,999 native-born South Korean respondents recruited through Qualtrics in January 2024, with random assignment to one of three framing arms (control, growth, fertility) producing arm sizes of approximately 660 to 700 respondents. The Immigration CBC module presented seven paired-profile tasks per respondent, yielding approximately 27,986 profile-level observations clustered within 1,999 respondents (about 9,300 per arm). We treat the respondent as the unit of clustering and compute robust standard errors accordingly (Esarey and Menger, 2019).

To benchmark the precision of our estimates, we compute minimum detectable effects (MDEs) on the percentage-point scale for two-sided tests at $\alpha = 0.05$ and 80% power, using the closed-form expressions in Schuessler and Freitag (2020). The within-respondent intraclass correlation in the conjoint outcome (forced choice) is approximately zero by design (each respondent has exactly five chosen and five unchosen profiles), so the design effect is approximately 1. Table D.1 reports MDEs for the principal estimand classes.

Estimand class	**Profiles per cell**	**MDE (pp)**
Pooled main-effect AMCE (e.g., Ethnicity)	19,990	1.40
Within-arm pooled AMCE	3,332	3.43
Treatment x origin AMCE difference	3,332	4.85
Treatment x origin x ethnicity (3-way) AMCE difference	1,666	6.86
Treatment x origin x skill (3-way)	1,666	6.86

Table D.1: Minimum detectable effect (MDE) by estimand class.

Note: Two-sided $\alpha = 0.05$, power $= 0.8$. MDEs use the achieved sample, the within-respondent intraclass correlation estimated from the data ($\rho \approx 0$), and the implied design effect (DEFF ≈ 1). The within-arm and three-way MDEs are the pooled MDE inflated by $\sqrt{2}$ for the relevant contrast.

Several of the directional effects highlighted in the manuscript fall below these MDEs. The fertility-cue attenuations of the non-US origin penalties (Philippines $+4.9$, Indonesia $+2.7$, China $+2.3$ percentage points; Table C.3) are substantively interesting but lie around or beneath the 4.85-point MDE for treatment-by-origin interactions. Reporting them as null effects under conventional null-hypothesis significance testing (NHST) is therefore misleading. The design lacks the precision to distinguish these from a true effect in the 1.5- to 5-point range. Equivalence testing with a justified smallest effect size of interest (SESOI) clarifies that the evidence supports the absence of *large* effects rather than the absence of effects (Lakens, 2017; Rainey, 2014).

We adopt a SESOI of five percentage points for treatment-by-origin interactions and policy-preference shifts. Five points represents one-third of the largest origin penalty observed in the experiment (the China-versus-U.S. AMCE of approximately 10 points) and approximates the smallest shift that would alter South Korea's stratified visa hierarchy in observable terms. An EPS quota adjustment of comparable magnitude affects roughly twenty thousand workers per year. Following Lakens et al. (2018), we use the two one-sided tests procedure. Each effect estimate is tested against -0.05 and $+0.05$, and equivalence to zero (within the SESOI band) is concluded only when both one-sided tests reject. We report the upper bound of the 90% confidence interval for each effect as the effect-size ceiling, following Rainey (2014).

Table D.2 reports the equivalence-test conclusions for the framing-experiment policy-preference effects (full numerical output is generated by the analysis pipeline).

Contrast	**Estimate (90% CI)**	**Equivalence to zero (SESOI ±5pp)**
Growth − Control on Maintain	$+6.5$ $[0.5, 11.9]$	Not equivalent. Substantive consolidation.
Growth − Control on Increase	-5.8 $[-11.2, 0.0]$	Not equivalent. Consolidation pulls from Increase.
Growth − Control on Decrease	-0.8 $[-5.2, 3.3]$	*Equivalent* within the SESOI band.
Birthrate − Control on Maintain	$+1.9$ $[-3.6, 7.9]$	Not equivalent. Underpowered null.
Birthrate − Control on Increase	-3.0 $[-8.8, 2.2]$	Not equivalent. Underpowered null.
Birthrate − Control on Decrease	$+1.1$ $[-3.2, 5.7]$	Not equivalent. Underpowered null.

Table D.2: Equivalence-test conclusions for framing-experiment policy-preference effects.

Note: Estimates are percentage-point shifts from the control arm. "Equivalent" means both one-sided tests against $\pm$5pp reject. "Not equivalent" means at least one one-sided test does not reject and the data cannot rule out a SESOI-sized effect.

The conclusion is that we have substantive evidence of consolidation under the growth cue, while the fertility-cue effects on direction are too imprecise to characterize as substantively zero. The data are consistent with anything from a small liberalizing fertility-cue effect to a small consolidation effect, but rule out a large effect in either direction. For the conjoint, treatment-by-origin AMCE differences for the China contrast are similarly underpowered: the Birthrate-Control China-USA contrast is $+2.3$ percentage points (90% CI -2.3 to $+7.0$), and the Growth-Control contrast is -1.4 percentage points (90% CI -6.3 to $+3.5$), both straddling the $\pm$5pp SESOI. Larger origin penalties (the 14-point China main effect, the 8-point ethnicity effect, the 22-point No-Korean penalty, and the 27-point No-job-seeking-plans penalty) are all detected with high power, well above the MDEs in Table D.1.

Appendix E Sociotropic Orientation and the Attribute Hierarchy

The main text reports that the headline attribute hierarchies (origin, ethnicity, language, occupation) are stable across framing arms. A natural follow-up is whether they are also stable across respondents' baseline sociotropic orientation. Figure E.1 reports marginal means for origin, ethnicity, Korean language, and occupation, split by the top-quartile sociotropic optimists ($n = 370$) and the rest ($n = 1{,}006$ skeptics). Optimists are, by construction, the most pro-immigration respondents on the abstract battery. Their attribute hierarchies are similar to the skeptics'. The China-versus-USA origin penalty, the non-Korean ethnicity penalty, the No-Korean language penalty, and the skill premium all reappear at the same rank order in both groups, with magnitudes overlapping within the 95% bands. Pro-immigration sociotropic reasoning shifts levels. It leaves the structure intact because respondents whose general orientation is open continue to evaluate specific candidates through the same prior commitments.

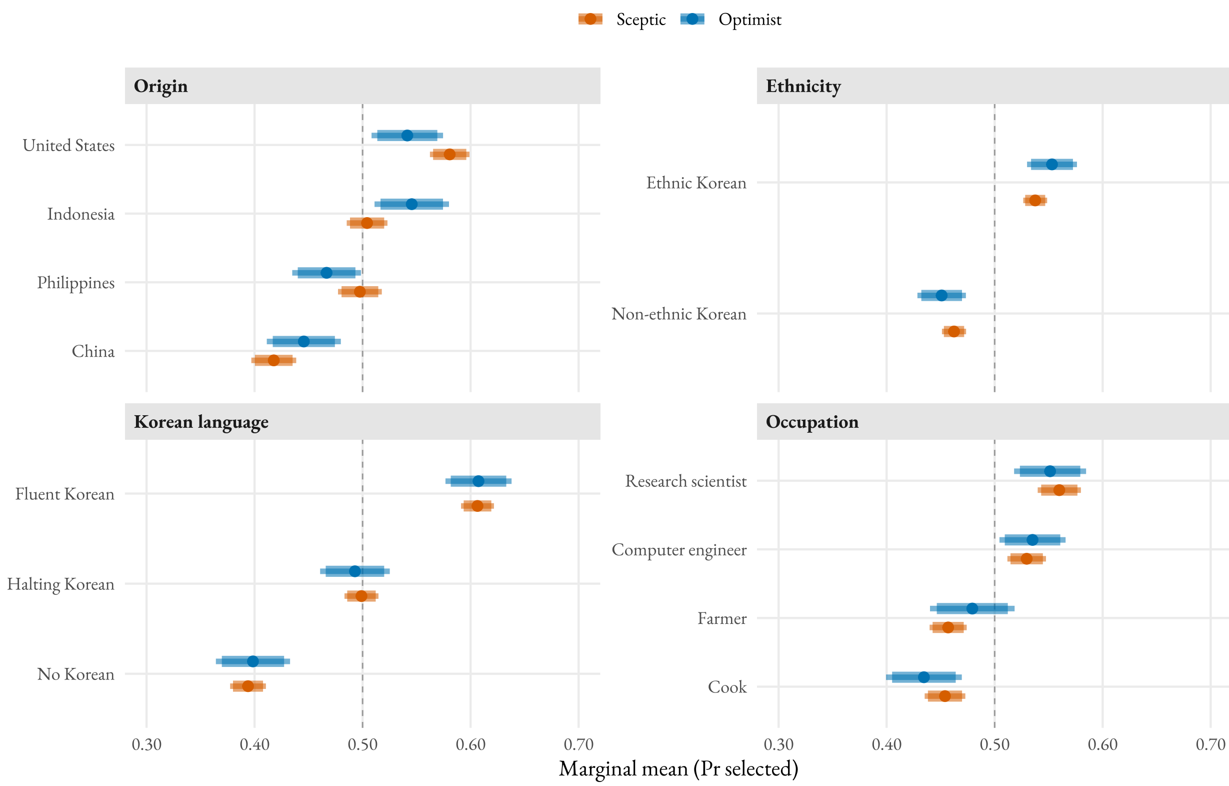

Figure E.1: Conjoint marginal means by sociotropic group. Prior commitments persist among the most pro-immigration respondents.

Note: Marginal means with respondent-clustered standard errors and survey weights. Sociotropic optimists are the top quartile of the pre-treatment sociotropic composite ($n = 370$). Skeptics are the rest ($n = 1{,}006$). Thick lines are 90% confidence intervals. Thin lines are 95%. The dashed vertical line at 0.5 marks chance selection.

Origin marginal means by sociotropic group and framing arm

Figure E.2 reports the conjoint counterpart to the policy-preference sociotropic subgroup analysis. The pattern matches the ideology and partisanship cuts in the main text in direction but is weaker in magnitude. Among optimists, the Chinese-versus-United States gap is roughly flat across the three arms (9.3, 8.0, 10.5 percentage points under Control, Growth, and Birthrate). Among skeptics, both cues widen the gap (7.4, 12.5, 12.2 percentage points). The same widening-on-the-resistant-side pattern that organizes the ideology and partisanship cuts appears here, with sociotropic priors substituting for ideological priors as the moderator. The skeptic group is also larger ($n = 318$, 310, and 378 per arm) than the optimist group

($n = 135$, 116, and 119), so the widening pattern is the more reliably estimated of the two.

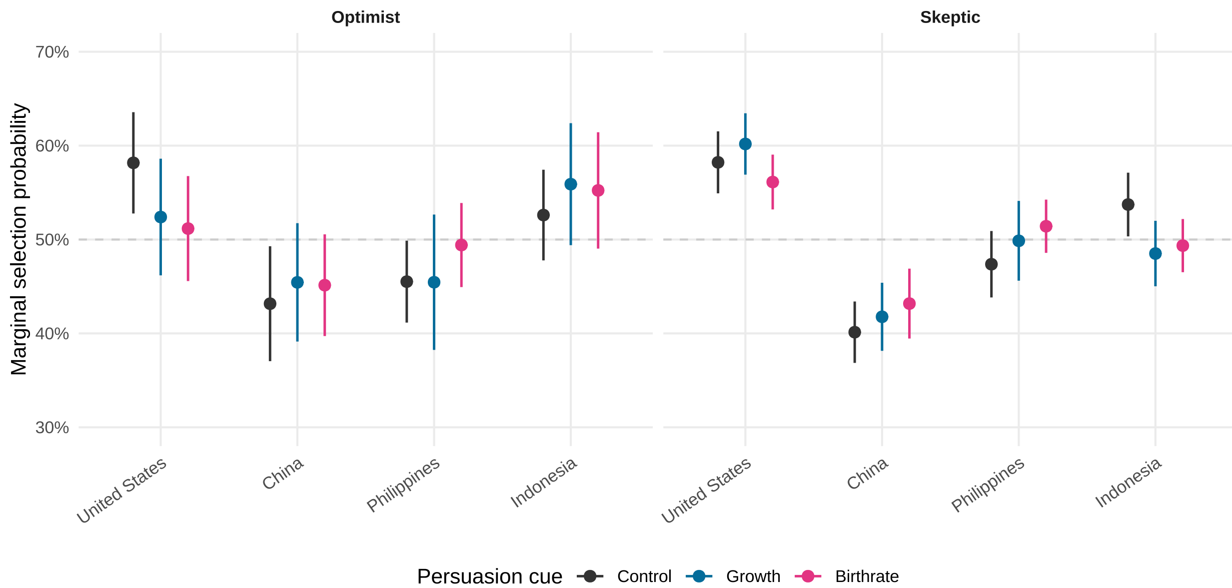

Figure E.2: Origin marginal means by persuasion cue, sociotropic group.

Note: Marginal selection probabilities for the four origin levels under each persuasion cue, separately for sociotropic optimists (top quartile of the pre-treatment composite) and skeptics (rest). Respondent-clustered standard errors and survey weights. Error bars are 95% confidence intervals. Reference line at chance selection (0.5).

Appendix F Statistical Significance Summary

Table F.1 consolidates every headline statistical test reported in the main text. The first four blocks are NHST tests where small p-values indicate a detectable effect. The equivalence-test block (against the $\pm$5pp SESOI of Appendix D) is the inverse. Small p-values mean the effect is bounded inside the SESOI band.

Test	Estimate	p	Sig.
Pooled framing effects on policy preference (multinomial logit, vs. Maintain)			
Growth — Increase	-0.313	0.015	*
Birthrate — Increase	-0.122	0.337	
Growth — Decrease	-0.195	0.220	
Birthrate — Decrease	+0.037	0.814	
Polarization (LPM): Cue × Ideology interactions			
Growth × Centrist on Maintain	+20.6	0.002	**
Birthrate × Centrist on Maintain	+4.3	0.507	
Growth × Conservative on Maintain	+26.2	$< .001$	***
Birthrate × Conservative on Maintain	+7.4	0.356	
Growth × Centrist on Increase	-7.6	0.225	
Birthrate × Centrist on Increase	+2.2	0.720	
Growth × Conservative on Increase	-11.0	0.133	
Birthrate × Conservative on Increase	+1.4	0.852	
Growth × Centrist on Decrease	-13.0	0.010	*
Birthrate × Centrist on Decrease	-6.5	0.192	
Growth × Conservative on Decrease	-15.2	0.011	*
Birthrate × Conservative on Decrease	-8.8	0.152	
Polarization (LPM): Cue × Partisanship interactions			
Growth × Independent on Maintain	-5.2	0.422	
Birthrate × Independent on Maintain	-4.8	0.449	
Growth × PPP on Maintain	+14.0	0.041	*
Birthrate × PPP on Maintain	+1.1	0.872	
Growth × Independent on Increase	+9.9	0.103	
Birthrate × Independent on Increase	+5.5	0.357	
Growth × PPP on Increase	-3.0	0.639	
Birthrate × PPP on Increase	-0.3	0.963	
Growth × Independent on Decrease	-4.7	0.341	
Birthrate × Independent on Decrease	-0.7	0.890	
Growth × PPP on Decrease	-11.0	0.036	*
Birthrate × PPP on Decrease	-0.8	0.878	
Co-ethnic preference (LPM on chosen)			
Birthrate vs. Control, Ethnic-Korean Unemployed profiles	+5.6	$< .001$	***
Birthrate vs. Control, low-skill Brazil profiles	+5.3	0.002	**
Birthrate vs. Control, low-skill China profiles	-5.3	0.001	**
Equivalence tests (TOST, ±5pp SESOI)			
Growth vs Control, Maintain	+6.5	0.671	
Birthrate vs Control, Maintain	+1.9	0.190	
Growth vs Control, Increase	-5.8	0.593	
Birthrate vs Control, Increase	-3.0	0.280	
Growth vs Control, Decrease	-0.8	0.050	†
Birthrate vs Control, Decrease	+1.1	0.080	

Table F.1: Summary of significance tests for all headline estimates reported in the main text.

Note: Pooled framing-effect estimates are multinomial-logit coefficients (relative to Maintain) and are expressed in log-odds; all other estimates are linear-probability-model coefficients in percentage points. Polarization interaction estimates are the Growth-cue (or Birthrate-cue) interaction with the listed subgroup category relative to the omitted Progressive (ideology) or Democratic-Party (partisanship) reference, on the listed outcome. Co-ethnic-preference LPMs control for all other conjoint attributes; survey weights applied; respondent-clustered SEs. The equivalence tests block reports the two-one-sided-test (TOST) p-value against a ± 5pp smallest effect size of interest. Significance codes: $^{\dagger}p < .10$; $^{*}p < .05$; $^{**}p < .01$; $^{***}p < .001$. For the equivalence-test rows, the † symbol marks rows where both one-sided tests reject (i.e., the effect is statistically equivalent to zero within the SESOI band).

Appendix G Conjoint Diagnostics and Robustness Checks

This appendix reports four standard conjoint diagnostics as robustness checks on possible design artifacts in the headline results: profile-position effects, task-fatigue, attention-pass sensitivity, and cue-reinforcement.

G.1 Profile-position effect

A position effect would arise if respondents preferred the left- or right-hand profile irrespective of attribute content. Table G.1 reports the mean selection rate by profile position and the cluster-robust contrast.

Table G.1: Profile-position effect (left vs right).

Position	Selection rate	N profiles
Left (Profile A)	50.1%	13993
Right (Profile B)	49.9%	13993
Right − Left (pp)	-0.14	
90% CI	[-1.32, +1.03]	
p-value	0.810	

The selection rate is 50.1% for Profile A (left) and 49.9% for Profile B (right). The contrast is -0.14 percentage points (90% CI $[-1.32, +1.03]$, $p = .81$) and is indistinguishable from zero. Respondents allocate attention symmetrically across the two positions.

G.2 Task-fatigue

Respondents complete seven paired tasks. If late-task responses are less attentive or anchored, attribute coefficients should drift with task number. Table G.2 reports the origin AMCE (against the United States baseline) computed separately on early (tasks 1–3) and late (tasks 4–7) blocks.

Table G.2: Origin AMCE (vs. United States) by task block. Estimates on the probability scale with respondent-clustered standard errors in parentheses.

Origin	Tasks 1-3	Tasks 4-7
China	-0.127 (0.018)	-0.153 (0.015)
Philippines	-0.081 (0.018)	-0.074 (0.014)
Indonesia	-0.040 (0.017)	-0.059 (0.015)

The China penalty is larger in the later block (-12.7pp in tasks 1–3 and -15.3pp in tasks 4–7), and the Indonesia penalty similarly widens (-4.0pp to -5.9pp). The pattern is consistent with respondents *intensifying* rather than disengaging from the discrimination structure as the task block progresses. We do not read this as fatigue in the disengagement sense, which would produce noisier, smaller estimates. It does indicate that any test using only early-task responses would understate origin penalties.

G.3 Attention-pass sensitivity

The instrument incorporated a manual attention check ("Please select strongly disagree", Qualtrics column `Q7...29`). The check was a hard gate at the Qualtrics layer, and 100% of finished respondents in the export passed. The analytical sample of $n = 1{,}999$ further drops five respondents missing on a raking dimension. To probe sensitivity, Table G.3 compares headline polarization estimates on the analytical sample to the broader attention-pass sample of $n = 2{,}027$ (the additional respondents are those who pass attention but are missing one or more raking dimensions).

Table G.3: Headline polarization estimates on the main analytical sample vs. a broader attention-pass sample (LPM, unweighted).

Sample	Estimand	Estimate (pp)	SE (pp)	p	n
Main ($n = 1{,}999$)	Growth × Centrist on Maintain	+26.71	6.64	< 0.001	1,999
Main ($n = 1{,}999$)	Growth × Conservative on Maintain	+27.63	8.17	< 0.001	1,999
Broad ($n = 2{,}001$)	Growth × Centrist on Maintain	+25.77	6.56	< 0.001	2,027
Broad ($n = 2{,}001$)	Growth × Conservative on Maintain	+27.99	8.10	< 0.001	2,027

The interaction estimates differ by no more than one percentage point across the two samples. The main analyses are insensitive to whether the raking-incomplete respondents are retained. Because all retained respondents passed the manual attention check at fielding, the analyses do not require a further attention-screen.

G.4 Cue-Reinforcement Before and After Reinforcement

By design the framing cue is reinforced after the third conjoint task to mitigate fade-out. Table G.4 reports the origin AMCE separately for the pre-reinforcement block (tasks 1–3) and the post-reinforcement block (tasks 4–7).

Table G.4: Origin AMCE (vs. United States) by reinforcement stage and framing arm. Percentage points (clustered SE in parentheses).

Origin	Post (tasks 4-7) — Control	Pre (tasks 1-3) — Control	Post (tasks 4-7) — Growth	Pre (tasks 1-3) — Growth	Post (tasks 4-7) — Birthrate	Pre (tasks 1-3) — Birthrate
China	-17.58 (2.48)	-10.36 (3.21)	-17.90 (2.57)	-13.35 (3.45)	-10.48 (2.78)	-14.45 (2.69)
Philippines	-11.55 (2.31)	-6.79 (2.99)	-9.70 (2.68)	-8.23 (3.25)	-1.23 (2.36)	-9.18 (3.04)
Indonesia	-8.50 (2.37)	-2.11 (3.11)	-6.65 (2.82)	-5.97 (2.94)	-2.58 (2.46)	-3.89 (2.96)

In the Control arm the origin penalties widen from the pre to the post block (China $-10.4 \rightarrow -17.6$pp, Philippines $-6.8 \rightarrow -11.6$pp, Indonesia $-2.1 \rightarrow -8.5$pp), a pattern consistent with within-task learning rather than disengagement. In the Growth arm the China penalty also widens slightly post-reinforcement ($-13.4 \rightarrow -17.9$pp). In the Birthrate arm, by contrast, the origin penalties *narrow* after the reinforced fertility cue (China $-14.4 \rightarrow -10.5$pp, Philippines $-9.2 \rightarrow -1.2$pp, Indonesia $-3.9 \rightarrow -2.6$pp). Read together, the diagnostic suggests that the cue-and-reinforcement design produces the expected cued effects on the post-reinforcement block while the Control-arm trajectory reflects ordinary within-task learning by respondents about how to discriminate among admission profiles.

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